STI

NK

JAW

“Such a shame to feel anything at all.” - Arvid

And let me offer lesson number one about America:

All great change in America begins at the dinner table.

- *Ronald Reagan, Farewell Address to the Union, 1989*

Jungeling
Rudy. 23.
Human. Son of Liliana and Frederik. Returned home from Columbia University after four years.

Muoter
Liliana. 65
Human. Matriarch of the Lockenverde household.

Krâja
Redford. 22
Self-proclaimed Thing.

Unholda
Salavar. ???
Beast. Voluntarily trapped within Rudy's radio.

Quemaling
Trucker. 44
Human. Stranded during a storm.

Êwawarto
STINKJAW. ???
Beast.

NOTES ON MAKING STINKJAW
The beast STINKJAW should be constructed. STINKJAW should be bigger than a human. It may be a puppet, or a structure, or a costume. It may be made of metal, or fabric, or mud. It may locomote, it may open its jaw, it may have arms to grab the Trucker, but none of it is truly necessary. Ultimately, its only need is it must be present, and it must be absolute.

STINKJAW should be visible to at least one audience member during every scene of the piece.

PART ONE **4**

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AUTUMN-WINTER

1983

“ The red rose cries, ‘She is near, she is near ;’

And the white rose weeps, ‘She is late ;’

The larkspur listens, ‘I hear, I hear ;’

And the lily whispers, ‘ I wait.’ ”

i – Rinta

A kitchen. Late Autumn. A large dining table across the centre of the stage. Various cabinets and stoves line the leftmost and back walls. A long strip of pines blanket the edges of the stage. Above a central cabinet, a portrait of the Virgin Mary hangs. She is conventional in depiction, head tilted as not to look the viewer in the eye. A photo of a man is framed on the cabinet. A shotgun hangs on a coat rack.

LILIANA enters STAGE LEFT. She holds a defrosted chunk of meat and a head of cabbage. She moves, cooking, filling a pot with water, opening the valve on the gas-canister below the stove before striking a match and lighting the stove, boiling the water. She turns away from the audience as she chops the cabbage and onion, singing quietly.

LILIANA
My Bárðr comes home after sundown,
He sleeps like a corpse in my arms,
His muscles bleed sugar and sapwood
His veins growing oaken and scarred

Bárðr I know where you came from
And Bárðr I know where youl'll go
Come summer your skin will sing sap-sweet
I'll feast on your bark and your bones

As LILIANA sings, she paces to the compost to discard the skins of the cabbage. From the back of the window, STINKJAW manifests, a single eye, watching.

LILIANA
We lay him to rest in the taproot
He sleeps like a beast in the pines
His muscles feed wormkin and wine cap
The rodents make homes in his spine

Oh, Bárðr I know where you came from
And Bárðr I know where you've gone
Da Bluot werdan da Bodam,
Da Bein wesan da wald-

STINKJAW opens its mouth slightly. A low, croning clackamore echoes, very gently, mimicking the rhythm of LILIANA's singing. She stops cooking and singing. She looks to the ceiling. Stays silent, listening. No other sound is made.

LILIANA
It seems the forest sings with me tonight.
Keep your songs to yourself, *wintar-wood*.
My son is coming home.

LILIANA clutches her rosary in one hand. With the other, she draws the symbol of the cross across her body, brings her hand from her solar plexus to her forehead, then keeps it suspended above her head.

As she performs this ritual, the lights fade to a single spotlight. Dust and dirt swirls around her like fireflies in the singular dusk light.

LILIANA
When Isla and I were children, she taught me how to track prints in the fresh mud after the rains. The four-foot of the hare. The strange, slanted gait of the coyote. The weight of an elk's hoof, fortuitous and imperial. I remember the morning after my first storm. I ran out looking for her once the bleating and trumpeting had stopped. Gnade uns Gott[1]. She had never taught me of any beast that leaves the print of an eye within the centre of its footstep.

LILIANA finishes her movements. She stays very still.

LILIANA
See him here safe.

[1] Woe betide you / Good God.

ii° – Sun

The lights come back to lantern-light. The food has finished being cooked and set on the table. RUDY stands in the doorframe. His hair is a little messy, his suit slightly dishevelled. They regard each other for a time.

LILIANA
I gave your mattress to the Devoirs last winter. They had a son.

RUDY
I am glad to see it found use in my absence.

LILIANA
I've padded your bedframe with what good hay and geese-down we have spare.

RUDY
It will suffice. I do not sleep much nowadays.
How is the birch tree?

LILIANA
It has grown stunted. A herd of doe took to it as a scratching post.

RUDY
Chased off?

LILIANA
Eaten.

RUDY
Mm.

LILIANA
I have cut the most stunted of the branches. It will grow stronger soon.

RUDY
I am glad to hear it.

A pause.

LILIANA
You've cut your hair.

RUDY
It was about time.

LILIANA
Mm.
LILIANA scribbles something on a piece of paper.
(Muttered) Der Junge braucht einen Rasierer[2].

RUDY
I have a gift for you.

RUDY reaches into his bag. He pulls out a mess of wires and places it on the table. It is a radio.

There is a channel I think you would like.
I will set it up tomorrow morning.

LILIANA
Ja. Thank you.

A pause.

Redford has moved into the old room.

RUDY
A pause.

Since when?

LILIANA
Two years.

RUDY
What did she-

LILIANA
It.

RUDY
Pardon?

LILIANA
It. Not she. It

RUDY
I don't understand.

[2] The boy needs a razor.

Lost its mother to the *gewitter* two autumns ago. Came here in the morning,
drenched in bile and sweat. Said it had trapped a young elk on its own.
Rope snares and meat hooks. It offered to share the meat if it could stay a fortnight.
Ten days from then – it brings home four rabbits.
Then a goose. In return for another fortnight. It lives with me now.

But what is-

It has chosen what it wants to be referred by. Ask it yourself if you mind so.

A pause. RUDY eats some of the food.

Then the beasts still make the forest their home?

The forest and beast are one and the same.

The forest is natural. They are not.

Nature is a word, *kind*[3]. Take your ink to the trees
and try and etch a boundary that lasts.

I am practiced, not a poet. I would take an axe
if I wanted to truly etch a mark.

Your words dress in as much bolster as you do.
See that mouth guarded.

I do not tie my words for vanity, mother.

Their ties shall prepare their nooses much better than twine.

RUDY eats in silence a moment longer.

Bring the men from the village. Bring guns,
bring fire. Bring dogs and knives and hate.
Give them a reason to fear us.

Fear us!

You have not seen New York City, mother.
The imperial fingers of change have never been more visible.
They have built concrete cages and dams of iron around riverways and reeds.
Electricity pumps heavy and thick through wires like elixir.
They have built a man from those roads.
And nature its dog.

REDFORD enters from the back door while RUDY talks. It holds a hare, bloodied, drops it on the kitchen counter. Listens to RUDY for a moment, before interjecting.

REDFORD
And what would that make you?

RUDY visibly starts.

REDFORD
One who feeds off both? A flea? Tick? Tumour?

RUDY, *flustered.*
Son.

[3] Child. Young. Pronounced “kin-de”

REDFORD
Of whom? The man or the dog?

LILIANA
Play nice, Redford.

LILIANA sees the hare.

LILIANA
Were they nested by the old distillery?

REDFORD
Quite so.

LILIANA
Guot[4]. I thought as much.

REDFORD
I did pity this one. Only stuck in the snare by the end of her foot. Little fighter almost got out by the time I got to her. Maybe I'll have a little more luck with it than she did.

RUDY stands up in formal gesture. Bows his head in a courtesy.

RUDY
Redford, I- It is a pleasure to see you again. I hope you have been-

REDFORD
Oh! What's this! They taught the village boy manners down south, it seems.

LILIANA
Let him.

REDFORD
To whom? The Prince of Pines? *To Rudy,* He'd grind your face through the mud to grow you a beard.

RUDY
I don't-

LILIANA, (*having finished eating).*
I retire. Put the lid on the pot before you sleep.
Rudy. Welcome home, *Lôrihhîn*[5].

LILIANA retires. RUDY and REDFORD stand. REDFORD spins on its heel and grabs the hare, throws it in an agile arc towards RUDY.

REDFORD
Yours.

---

[4] Good.
[5] Rabbit.

RUDY flinches and doesn't catch it. Quickly scrambles to pick it up.

REDFORD
Bastard! Good meat, that one. RUDY
I- Apologies.

(*Gestures to the hare)* Apologise to dent-head first. She'll be feeling that one all night.
Head, aches, thump, thump, thump. *Beat*. What? Put the poor thing in the freezer.
Least you can do is chill her wound. You want the blood to seep into her brain?
Painful, that.

Very well.

RUDY goes to leave. Starts. Lingers in the doorframe for a moment.

Redford. I- I am glad to see you well. *Beat.* I-

REDFORD abruptly makes a squelching sound. Cocks its head to one side, limp like a corpse. Points to the hare.

Bleagh. Out of time, you are. Blood fills her head, vision fades to black. Killed her dead, you did.
Go dig her grave, killer boy. To the cold room for the cold blooded.

RUDY stares for a moment. Turns and leaves. REDFORD watches for a moment, then flits across the kitchen. Sits longingly under the portrait of the Virgin Mary.

I dragged home a rabbit today. Stone dead, feet drowned in bad luck.
What have you dredged home now, Killer Queen?

REDFORD listens to the portrait. There is silence. It makes a mock shocked face.

He's not your doing? Then who-

Oh.

REDFORD slowly crawls across the kitchen counter, looking to the bare window. It slowly peers around the window frame, before making contact with STINKJAW's eye. Redford exaggerates a gasp, falls backwards off the counter in a intent motion and gently lands on the floor.

REDFORD
You pervert! And how long has your voyeurism lasted? *Beat*
What are you looking for? It cannot be food,
you would have plucked me like a chicken
the moment I stepped foot in the grove! It
cannot be shelter, there must be cities of freaks
to return home to. Troglodytes frolicking
in the gardens and jackalopes on every
silver platter. Maybe you *are* a pervert.

REDFORD stands up. Coyly looks to the window.

I wonder, where *does* a beast like you get off?

Up here?

REDFORD brings both its hands to its face.

Or down

REDFORD twirls its hands down to its trouser leg. Reveals its calf in mock seduction.

here?

Oh, nothing? Entertain me, stink-thing.
How can one enjoy watching knowing prey?
What remains then but[6]-

RUDY enters. REDFORD somersaults backwards. Lands, adjusts its trouser leg.

REDFORD RUDY
What-

My leg itches. There is no crime in scratching.
There is no crime in sleeping, either. *Goodnight.*

REDFORD exits. RUDY stands, disoriented. He eventually turns to the window. Walks over to it. Looks cautiously out of it. Grabs the latch, opens the window.

RUDY
Hello?

STINKJAW is gone. RUDY closes the window. Looks around the room. Begins cleaning his bowl.

RUDY
Homecoming. David home to his manor. Elias back to the isles. And I am…
Well. All in good time, I know.
Time and grit. The truest weapons of a young man.
RUDY washes his bowl in silence.
Four years!
RUDY continues washing his bowl. Places it down. Grabs his bag. Gets ready to leave.
RUDY stops at the cabinet. Looks to the portrait of the Virgin Mary.

Hello.
I trust you have been faithful in your duties.

RUDY looks to the portrait of the man. Brushes some dust off of the frame.

Tomorrow we listen to the news.

RUDY nods to himself. Goes to leave.
Clicking and cicadas. Frogs croak and trees whine. A fox screeches. The sounds continue to build, the rustling leaves increasing in volume until,

[6]"…the anticipation of anticlimax?"

III – Forazeihhan

The lights come on. It is bright daylight. RUDY has changed, wearing a much cleaner suit, sat at the table, holding the radio and its wires. REDFORD sits on the table, watching.

REDFORD
Four years for a box of talk and a talking box.

RUDY
A friend of mine specialises in telecommunication.
He designed this machine last summer.
Have you ever seen anything like it before?

REDFORD
I know what a radio is, Rude.

RUDY
From factories, but not from love.
She is built like an organ. A thousand veins
Of iron and rubber.
Copper wire and electrodes.
Electrically charged life.

REDFORD
Electrically charged wires.

RUDY
Tied and bound by a hand of God.

REDFORD
God of spasms, maybe.

LILIANA enters.

RUDY
Good morning, mother.

LILIANA
Morgan[7]. Did you hear the peepers last night?

RUDY
Ardently.

REDFORD
Agitated, they were. Something's scratching at our grove.

RUDY
A beast?

LILIANA
I pray not.

REDFORD
We do have fresh blood wafting from our walls. Blind blood, at that.

LILIANA
Redford. Do not invite the spirits of upturn into our house. Rudy is not new blood.

[7] Morning.

REDFORD
New, no. Naïve? Hm.

LILIANA
Rudy. I go to the markets on Thursdays. Is there anything you need?

RUDY
Ah, yes. Anchovies, if you will.

LILIANA
Very well.

RUDY
You do not want to stay for the radio?

LILIANA
It will be working when I am home, no?
Einen schönen tag noch[8]. Look after yourselves.

LILIANA leaves. REDFORD has been staring at RUDY since "anchovies".

REDFORD
Anchovies? Trying to tame a woodcat, are you?

RUDY
I knew someone who swore by them. They are good for the blood.

REDFORD gets up.

REDFORD
So is walking. You sure you don't want to come with me?

RUDY
I would like to finish my work here.

REDFORD, *standing up*.
Very well.
Enjoy your metal Lazarus.

RUDY
Redford-

REDFORD
Hm?

RUDY
Enjoy your hunt.

[8] Have a nice day.

REDFORD sticks out its tongue at RUDY. It leaves. RUDY'S eyes follow REDFORD as it goes. He eventually returns to the radio. Finishes wiring up the radio. Exclaims in joy as it begins rumbling slightly.

REAGAN (*Automated)*

…but I will say this: A President should never say "never." But I'm going to violate that rule and say "never". I will never stand for…

The radio cuts off. RUDY frowns. Moves a few wires. The radio comes back on.

…A President should never say "never." But I'm going to violate that rule and say "never"…. I will… never… rule… never… A president… I will… never…

The entire room flashes a deep red, for a split second. The radio changes channels instantly. RUDY confusedly looks at the radio.

COREY HART (*Automated)*
You can never surrender
And when the night is cold and dark
You can see, you can see light
'Cause no one can take away your right
To fight and to never surrender
To never surrender…

Static begins building. The radio changes channels again, a screeching sound. The stations slowly overlap.

BUSH (*Automated)*
But America is not in decline. America is a rising nation……
weakness and ambivalence lead to war. Weakness and ambivalence lead to war.
You see -- You see, weakness tempts aggressors. Strength stops them. I will not allow this country to be made weak again. Never.

REAGAN (*Automated)*
I'm going to… say never….

The choruses of Nevers continue to build, as the entire room starts shaking. RUDY cowers. A fourth voice is added to the chorus, harsh and grating.

SALAVAR
NEVER NEVER NEVER NEVER AI AI AI AHHHJJJJJJJ K K K K K K K AM AMAM AM WAH AH AH AH AH AH, SPERMLISIN SIR, IT'S SPERMLISIN. SPERMLISIN AND COBALT. COBALT AND COTTON AND I DID NOT HAVE SEXUAL RELATIONS WITH THAT WOMAN. DO YOU HEAR ME? I NEVER HAD- I NEVER- I AM THE FACE ON EVERY BILLBOARD, THE CHAMPION OF OUR NATION, I AM EVERY WHITE STAR SPECKLED ACROSS THE NYLON FABRIC OF A SPANGLED DRESS I- FLAG- I- I – BLUE AND WHITE, BLUE AND WHITE AND-

The cupboard that the radio is placed on shudders violently. SALAVAR screams. A deep RED light glows from the radio and cupboard. Then, one by one, the panels fall off, revealing a cage inside. It is see through – little more than a box. There is somebody inside, crushed within. It looks extremely uncomfortable. A long silence.
As SALAVAR speaks, a voice is projected out the speaker of the radio.

SALAVAR
Hello?
Hello?

RUDY stares in terror.

RUDY
Copper and electrodes. I look at metal and charge. No more, no less the- the sum of the parts are closed.

SALAVAR
KID!

Stop boggling at me like that, will you? Looking like you've seen a-

SALAVAR looks around, sees the radio.

Like I'm some kind of-

Heh-

Stretches his fingers. SALAVAR laughs, maniacally, victoriously.

It's over! It's- I'm- I'm- GOING TO SAY NEVER-

Amazing. Amazing. *(To Rudy)* I'm sorry- I don't think I- THEY'RE DOING WHAT IN THE SEWAGE[9]? I- I C – C - K K K K (*Gasps)* KID! How far are we from the east river?

RUDY, not saying anything, backs out the room.

SALAVAR
Shit. Probably not in the forests anymore huh?
Not… in the… forests…

Salavar laughs again.

God! I never thought I'd god-damn do it! I feel so…
Artificial.

SALAVAR feels his hair. Picks a paper out of it.

What's this?

[9] Woodstock 99. Many people danced in the septic tanks thinking it mud.

The year is 1983. We are in… ah- still New York. Only a mile from the river, actually. Hm. David Bowie hits the charts with his newest single… Margret Thatcher will be reelected as prime minister of… the Soviet Union collapses in eight years? How-

RUDY reenters with REDFORD. REDFORD is halfway into trapping gear.

REDFORD
Your toy not working?

RUDY
It's *talking*.

REDFORD
You are a strange one, aren't you?

RUDY
It speaks like a man. Screams. Hear- listen.

…

And in the meantime our food escapes from my-

SALAVAR
KID?

Come here, will ya? Is it true that-

The gales of change. They howl past my ears from moment to moment. It is not what I hear that scares me. It is the stench of rotting flesh on the winds.

REDFORD
So it's a poetry station.

SALAVAR
I am scared how those winds will push me. Who am I to claim I would be stalwart to the storm?

REDFORD
A theatric poetry station.

SALAVAR
Are you even listening to me? Something *fucked* is happening-

REDFORD
-An interactive theatric poetry station-

SALAVAR
-*One* more adjective! Can it get *one* more adj-

REDFORD
-A *sarcastic* interactive th-

RUDY
For god's sake! (*Towards the radio.)* Can you hear us?

SALAVAR
YES! Loud and clear! I'd let you check my ears if- *(Small Giggle)* – if I had any.

RUDY
Look. It talks. It *knows*.

REDFORD
Curious.

Beat.

Either way, we cannot eat a radio tonight, can we?

REDFORD turns to leave.

RUDY
But-

REDFORD
If you want to get used to being in these woods again, learn to live with the *weird*. If it doesn't have any teeth and it doesn't have any claws it's not going to kill you. So- make friends with it. Take it for lunch- I don't know. Some of us need to provide, Rudy.

REDFORD exaggeratedly blows a goodbye kiss. Spins out the door.

RUDY stares fearfully at the radio. SALAVAR is partially pulling papers out of his hair.

SALAVAR
That's a weird one, huh?

Kid- wait- don't run on me- I'm seeing here that- is the Berlin Wall still standing?

RUDY
Yes.

SALAVAR
Uh- I'm getting mixed messages here. "*Wall's fall regains Berghain"*- Here's something about a Redford. Do you know a Redford?

RUDY gathers his belongings and leaves. Salavar is focused on a piece of paper.

Kid? Don't go quiet on me, I'm seeing something on- oh.

SALAVAR has focused on a bit of paper. He scrutinises it.

Shit…

LILIANA enters. She hurries to the kitchen, grabs a few small jars out the cupboard, puts them in her bag and turns to leave.

SALAVAR
Hey! Hey! You! Listen! I need to tell you-

LILIANA sees the radio.

Hi, pleasure to meet you, sorry to skip the pleasantries but-

LILIANA walks over towards the radio.

Wait, listen up lady, there's only a decade before the world-

LILIANA walks over to the radio and turns it off. The lights turn off immediately.

iv – Ubamorgane

The lights fade up on RUDY. It has been a week since the last scene. He sits, prodding at food by the table on his own. He pokes the chicken on his plate.

RUDY
White meat. Two choices in this world.
Red or white. Red, or white. Rouge ou blanc[10]?
My roommate would by rote bring home
Wrapped slices of bloody meat night after night.
Filled with iron, thick with cholesterol
to grow muscle, to grow our hair thick, to
Grow into that of our forefathers.
He did not know how to cook it well.
It was gamey, taut, stiff, turgid in your teeth,
But still we ate it. Night after night after
Night bovine flesh would tend like fertiliser
to our frames, the rushing heat of zinc pumped
hearts and saturated veins. Steeped our minds.
The first night I slept at hers, she apologised,
She could not cook in time for my arrival,
And hastily pulled chicken from the oven.
Breaded. Lumped. Processed. White.
It tasted like
RUDY sits on this for a moment.
Change.

Flea? Or Tick? Or Tumour?
Son. Son of the city. Son of the iron man.
What does that make her? What does that make *it*?
Daughter-child-thing of the litters?
How its hair has grown! How its *tongue*! Long and wild
And tumbling, what happened to the timid
Girl who would not look me in the eye
When I spoke? O, Great Lord that you are
Why rip the organ of innocence
From her throat, shove the stinted shard of
Cynicism wherein instead? I am
Maybe too eager to judge. It has been
Less than a tenday since homecoming.

[10] This line lies in reference to a line from Tristan and Iosode – "Noir ou Blanc?" Rudy would know this.

Yet still, if I am to settle for a time,
There is no concrete foundation set in
These lands of cicada, pine and root.
Past, yes, but not tradition. Not truly.
There is nothing historic about the
Lockenverdes.

There is still a man in the radio.
He has not left. He raves of tomorrows
And bad ends. Mother does not use the thing
And Redford does not care. He waits for me
Even now. To talk to him. To see him.

RUDY finishes his food. Hesitantly makes his way to the radio. Looks to the portrait of Mary on the wall.

RUDY, *to the portrait.*
Watch.

RUDY turns the radio on. The radio bursts straight into SALAVAR's conversation. The walls of the closet begin declining, a slow, lazy red looming out, revealing SALAVAR, uncomfortably trying to lie on his stomach, talking into a large brick in his hand.

SALAVAR
Keith, that's what I've been saying this whole time! You've got talent, don't let it go to waste; bring the art to the people, not the people to the art! Your art has gotta be like a girl from Queens, loud, obnoxious and- AHJ HHHHAUUHHH FOR THE LOVE OF GOD I CAN'T NOT *Huge breath of air* Bring it to the raving, stupid masses, Keith. Bring it to me.

SALAVAR sees RUDY.

Sorry, I gotta take this. Talk to you soon. Love the dogs.

SALAVAR shoves the brick into his shirt.

SALAVAR
Thought you'd run away for good at this point, kid.

RUDY
Why my radio? Why invade this home?

Invade is a harsh word to swing around, you know.
Most people prefer "occupy" or "assimilate".

Listen to me. How do I get rid of you?

We only just met, kid! You just made a new friend and you're already at snapping at his cable calves to get him out the door? You know, in my day, we're going to have some decency.

RUDY glowers.

Come on! More than just a cold shoulder you're giving me here. Just- try it. Ask me my name.

Pause. Rudy straightens.
Good Evening. My name is Rudy Lockenverde. It is a pleasure to make your acquaintance.
May I please have your name?

Oh, well ya can't keep it.

RUDY glares.

BAH- AH come ON kid! You're so *stiff*. Loosen up, You're at home, aren't you?

Not… quite.

Tomato Tornado. Either way, name's- DIANA FRANCIS SPENCER-

SALAVAR breaks into a coughing fit. The radio rumbles slightly as he does.

Salavar. Salavar Salavar.

RUDY stares. Begins to go to turn the radio off.

No- no- I'm not fucking with you kid- I'm not- AUGH-
WOULD YOU CUT IT WITH THE DOGS!
This isn't- WAIT!

You are devil-spawn. How dare you *infest* this hom-

No! I'm no devils! There are no demons- TAKE YOUR SATANS
AND SHOVE THEM DOWN[11]- kid just- just don't TURN THE
DAMN RADIO OFF!

RUDY pauses.

I'm not a devil. I'm from the forests- I'm-

RUDY turns the radio off. Stands there for a couple moments. Then, turns it back on.

Forest-beast can't talk.

Not that you know of.

Forest-beast don't speak like humans.

Not that you knew of.

You said you weren't hellbourne. What separates those trees from-

Kid, what do you think hell is? Hell, what do you think Christianity is?
You think we had a many legged Thing out there dutifully crawling out
onto the trunk of a mangrove and patiently waiting for roots of jagged flint
to impale it into salvation? That one's all you.

The devil wears many faces. And bodies.

So do your churches. You know the name "Gauthe" at all?

What?

I suppose not.

SALAVAR plucks a piece of paper.

"Dwarfed by Gauthe are the steeples endorsed[12]."
Watch Louisiana, kid. Your devil
sloughs off holy robes and suits alike.

You talk like a prophet.

I talk like a forecast, kid. Prophets have agendas. I have, well.
Look. It's clear you had a bad rep of what I am before you
turned these dials back to up 100. So what gives?

[11] It is likely Salavar is referencing the satanic panic.
[12] Gilbert Gauthe is the first catholic priest in the US to face a widely public sexual abuse trial in 1984.

You're in our radio.

Tough luck. Get a new radio if it bothers you that much. I'm here to stay.

You're in my radio. It's important to me.

Ah. Personal attachment. Hasn't minimalism
already kicked its way around?

How do I get you out? Why- You're truly forest-folk?

Through[13] and Bough.

Forest-Things are wooden. There is nothing artificial about their form.

Damn right, natural as muck.

(Immediately) Then you lie!

I do not lie! I HAVE SEEN THE UNYIELDING INFINITY
OF HISTORY GRIND TO PARADOXICAL HALT
I do not lie! I have been the gnarled growths of lump and limb!
I have seen from every orifice of my body and drooled
from every pore. And you know what, kid?
I hated it. I hated the stinking gore, the mudded flesh,
the sheer, absolute, *physicality* of it all.
So I died. I turned my plasma to frequency and my eyes to zeroes.
And now, with the smoke cleared and the nodes polished,
I am like
Lightning.

You- you speak of-

Resurrection.

No! To take a body so tangible and mince it through the filter of binary would destroy yourself.
You cannot! You could not!

Again – resurrection. I am the neatly wrapped
second coming. Digitised and boxed for your convenience.

Pause.
That was a lie.

That was a *joke*! I'm no messiah. I was just a thing with a dream.
Now I'm just the dream. Maybe all I ever was.

RUDY picks up the radio, starts fiddling with it.

Watch it! I don't know where your hands have been!

There must be corruption somewhere in here.
I must be able to find the broken machinery and replace the error. Or, as you insist, soul.

Mm.

A pause. RUDY snaps the back of the radio off. Takes the batteries out. SALAVAR doesn't go anywhere.

Find anything nasty?

Startled; How are you vocal?

Don't take my word for it kid, but I might be a *teeny* bit transcendent.
More hunch than hard truth but the whole future seeing thing lends me some credence to being a whole- you know – non temporal situation.

[13] Pronounced like Bough.

I get this itchy feeling I'm not just some cathode.

There is no validity to you having true clairvoyance.

Oh come on! You see this one all the time! How should I prove it?
Tomorrow's lottery numbers are 17 19 23 43 21!
The Yankees lose to the Mariners 5-0 next week!
Next year the president is going to be R-

Ronald Reagan. The others are merely speculation.
Everyone in the city speaks like he's already won again.

What about who will be elected in 88?

RUDY thinks.
Bush, likely.
Reagan's influence isn't going to be shaken easily, I think.

More than you know, kid- Okay, fine.
Something more-
GOOD EVENING, LADIES AND GENTLE[14]-
personal.
How about… the day of the next storm?

You are forest thing. Of course you would know.

The date of your death?

There would only be one way to prove that.
Redundant.

Okay. Fine. Something you could know.
I'll give you the date of something passed, based on
its superposition in the future, and you can be witness. So!
The date of… your… dads… fifth anniversary since his passing
will be… three weekends from now. Huh? Hm?

RUDY stares.

Gotcha! I knew I'd get you eventually.
I can do another if you want! Your… *birth*-

Father isn't dead.

Hm?

He's not dead. He left to raise money for us.

No, no. I could *feel* I was correct, kid.
It's like an- itch- I feel. I know I'm r-

Father isn't dead!
Your deceit runs deep, muck-thing.

Kid-

I am banishing you from this home.
To come uninvited and spout like Father is-

AND HE'LL ONLY BE THE FIRST. THERE ARE MANY
THAT WILL FALL FOR THE PROMISE OF DIE WENDE[15]
MAYBE HIS BRAINS DASHED AGAINST THE BRICKS
WILL PAVE A PATH FOR GREAT AMORPHOUS
MATRIMONY.

Stop talking like you *know*!

I DO KNOW! I KNOW EVERY BLOATED PORE

[14] Should be said attempting to mimic David Letterman.
[15] German unification following the fall of the Berlin Wall. More metaphorical in Salavar's mind.

ON THE FACE OF EVERY BLOATED MAN
I KNOW THE GENIUS OF THE THINK BREAK
AND I KNOW THE THINK TANK IN THE STARS
THAT WILL UNITE TRUTH YOUTH AND TOOTH
UNDER ONE DESPICABLE AND GORGEOUS WEB.
AND MOST OF ALL I CAN SEE FREDERIK
LOCKENVERDE, SOCKETS GOUGED AND BODY FLAYED
LIKE THE LAST SOLDIER OF-

RUDY turns and kicks the side of the cabinet. Hard. The entire room distorts and SALAVAR screams. It calms down eventually. RUDY sits on the ground. A long silence.

Okay.
I'm sorry. I didn't mean to upset a new friend.
Here. Consolidation divination, on the house.
The world ends in seventeen years.

Leave my radio.

Dead serious. The great "Y" "2" "K!" will be the death of us all.
It probably isn't the best time to tell you but-

Go away.

I can't see the future past the year two thousand.
That's our expiration date. Who knows how it ends?
I haven't figured that out yet. It's hard to see the light around a black hole.

RUDY gets up. Picks up his bag. Goes to leave.

Kid. Nothing I've said today has been a lie.
I don't need you to trust me, but I need you to believe me.
You can't see it from where you are, but I promise you,
It's a small world out there.

The lights fade as RUDY leaves.

V – Sterro

The lights stay off. Slowly, faint white lights begin dotting up in the ceiling above – stars. The night sky is alive.
REDFORD enters with a stack of papers. Begins laying them out on the table. Looking up to the stars, it begins writing. Intently. Under its breath, it mutters;

REDFORD

What does that make me?
In a world of half-beliefs?
I've kicked and I've died
For a hundred lives
And I still can't seem to see.
Just what that should make me.
Like the first primal beast that learned to dream
Whose brain stopped surviving and started to live.

REDFORD stands on the table. Listens to the sky.

REDFORD
I do wonder if a part of her still breathes out there.
Not in flesh, but in sense and sensation.
Hidden in the woodwork and pinewoods.

Maybe a hint of her agony stains the boards of our house
Maybe her laughter might still be heard if you listen close enough to
The rustle of leaf in the heat of summer.

Maybe she stills live on in a heartbeat.

RUDY enters, abruptly. Starts when he sees REDFORD.

REDFORD

I think an apology from you first;
"Oh Redford, I apologise deeply
And profusely for disturbing your time
Of silence and cosmos, I will promptly
Return to my bed and slumber until
The next age of man comes forth in the shape
Of information, rest, and quanta."

RUDY
Awake at this hour?

I feel restless. My dreams do not feel my own.
I dream of thrashing legs and impulse. I am
the beast of the undergrowth, anticipation
in my spit and heat in my muscles. But
I can not truly feel if I am hunter
of the trees, or the prey to be
sunk between one's jaws.
I do not want to sleep
Anymore.

And thus spoke the lost and languid.
Catalogue your thoughts. Maybe you
Can return to concrete and pay a man
To tell you what it all means.

A pause. RUDY sits down.

I did not know you astronomer.

There is a body trapped in the stars. I want to free them,
I can see the crows feet holding their eyes in the Ursae,
And their beating heart still rich in the sprawling galaxy above us.
I want to truly capture their beauty. The cosmological oxymoron.
Traced on sheets of paper. Though, I fear,
One does not turn themselves to stardust to be perceived.
But thus is bodykinds conquest. To know all but ourselves.

Beat

What are you?

Redford.

You choose this?

I choose nothing. I simply am. Did you choose to pave your mind?

Yes.

Could you go back?

No.

Then how much of a choice truly was it?

…

Has mother been a good guardian to you?

Which one?
The one of skin? Greatly so.
The one of oil? Too passive for my liking.

She is exemplar.

To whom? The manor-dog? The dying soul? The city boy?

…

Rudolph Lockenverde, what is it you truly want?
Answer wisely. The stars aren't the only ones watching tonight.

The radio is off.

You're not the only one with friends from the forest. Above us.

RUDY and REDFORDs gazes trail up. STINKJAW is revealed looming high above the stage.

Don't scream. It likes subtlety.

Terrified. Lord in heaven.

Not quite.

What is that?

A set of teeth. Eye sockets. A body.

How long has it been there?

Tonight? As soon as I set up, I think. Further back?
I don't think you want to know the answer to that question.

Does Mother know?

"Mother" has ears like wildgrass and eyes of a falcon.
"Mother" has lived and breathed the air filtered through

the blighted leaves of this forest for decades. So, of course “Mother” knows best.
For “Mother”, and “Redford” both know that the best way to survive a bear is to play dead.
And the best way to survive a man? That’s to play along.

That is no man.

Isn’t it? Maybe not in body.

I cannot do this.

You were the one who returned home.

I had no choice- I had to-

Rudy.
REDFORD grabs RUDY’s hand. RUDY locks up.
The forest can not hurt you if you play by its rules. You reek of change.
Artificial change. The type that favours chemical over time.
If you cannot wash the scent off, at least mask it with mud.
All you do is wander, Rudy. You do not hunt, you do not garden,
You just sit and stare at your radio.

I am aimless here.

Then pick a direction and start running. I chose up.

Looking to STINKJAW.
Is it truly safe?

Ha! No. But it has needs. And wants. Just like us.
You could greet it, if you want.
Just stand on the table, and look up to it.
Reach your hand out, if you’re brave.

REDFORD stands up, pulls RUDY onto the table. Mesmerised, RUDY looks up to the towering STINKJAW. It breathes slowly. RUDY begins extending his hand. It is still an infinity away from the beast.

Now greet it.

Hello. My name is Rudy Lockenverde.

Good. Now greet it. *With its name.*

I don’t know-

REDFORD leans over and whispers into RUDY’s ear.

Ready?

Hello *Stink-*

Hello, *S-*

The lights, RUDY and REDFORD and STINKJAW demanifest immediately.

VI - Regan

A drop of water. Another. Then another. Slowly, a gentle downpour begins.
LILIANA stands in the kitchen. She has a bowl in her hand. She looks out the window.

LILIANA
Palatinate. Germany. Sixteen sixty seven.
A hundred years of wars to carve out a story.
The Spanish, the Bavarians, the French.
It seemed our land was receptive to *blout*[16].
Somebody, someone, and someone else,
All ended an old life on a boat to the Isles.
To flee from razed fields and slaughtered sons.
Then some of those someone's started
Another life on a boat to the Colonies.
To flee crowded cities and filthy daughters.
In the chasing of *die frehiet*[17]. Mother freedom.
Mother forest. *Muoter Sun.* Mother tongue.
Mother's tongue. Good stories, I must imagine.
Worthy lives. Defined by their turmoil, yes,
but too defined by ambition and
by the dream of greener forests
than home. The animal instinct to live
The human instinct to be happy.
And then, sometime, came the Lockenverdes.
Heirs to the forests. Children of settling.
For three hundred years we have sat and lived
To be picked off. To grow our numbers
like rabbits. Our ancestors fought
To make us fodder to forces they could
Not know. Dear *Got*! *Ich wunske leben*[18]*!*
Let our family be remembered by more than fear.

RUDY enters. He looks anxious, slightly dishevelled. He drops a gardening tool by the table.

LILIANA
You did not finish eating.
I do not feel hungry tonight. My stomach feels wrong. As if there is an itch
I just cannot reach nestled in my intestine.
It is the weather.
Can you tell, smog-littered as you have become?
A storm lingers on the horizon.
Long Pause.
Father isn't going to come home.
No. He stopped sending money in your third year.
It had been diminishing, month
by month, prior to the abandon. He did not write following.
Where was the last you heard of him?

[16] Blood.
[17] The Freedom.
[18] I want to live!

LILIANA thinks.
Syracuse. To the west.
How come he did not travel to the city?
Maybe he did.
Maybe that was why he disappeared.
He was pulled feet-first into the city of promise and night suns.
Who would return from an intoxicant as ambrosial as that?
I did.
Did you?
Pause.
Why did you stay here, mother? The cities. They promise a fresh future.
You could have sold the house.
Moved on. I wasn't here. Father wasn't here.
What does it matter to you? My life is my own.
I do not contest that. I just do not understand.
Nobody is trying to make you understand.
Mother-
Rudolph. Will you finish your food?
I do not think so. I'm sorry.
Mm.

LILIANA collects the food. Pours it back into a large pot.

I will be in the garden.

LILIANA leaves. RUDY stands on his own for a while. Looks up to the portraits. Opens his mouth. Changes his mind. Eventually walks over to the radio. Turns it on. SALAVAR is staring absentmindedly into space.

RUDY SALAVAR
Hello? Salavar?
I dream of flying. I dream that my body will lift me through the air.
Where gravity is suggestion. King of electricity,
I need purpose beyond cycle.
Can you give me that?
Salavar?
Have you ever kissed someone, Rudolph?
…Yes.
Describe it to me.
I don't understand.
Why do you need to? Just. Do it.
It was an evening in city autumn.
Leaves as ornaments rather than landscape.
I had known her for five months. I think I knew
I loved her when she showed me her home.
There was one night where we watched the TV.
A man made faces at us through the cathodes.
Everything was so structured. It felt real.
She turned to me and asked "Do you want to kiss me?"

Did you?

I wanted to marry her. I didn't feel a rush when I kissed her.
I didn't feel the hot passion or searing heat or pumping flesh
when I pressed my lips to hers.

What did her skin taste like?

RUDY thinks.

Matriculation.

Into what?

I still have not found out.

…

Is a storm coming?

Yes.

How bad?

Do you really want to know?

Yes.

For you folks? Not the worst.
It's going to be centred south of the river.
The Dohman's down there are going to have it bad.
A grandfather. Their youngest daughter.
Taken by a centipede and a portent respectively.

Can't we warn them?

Too late, kid. You couldn't warn them in time, even if you tried.
And they knew the dangers, living here. You all do.

Beat
How long have you been- electric?

Three weeks.

So you-

Yep. You met me as a newborn current.

I didn't realise. I thought this was. Older.

Feels it, doesn't it.

Was it worth it?

No- YES!
Is being human worth it?

It's… being human.

Exactly. This is just me now. Beast-turned-electric.
I don't know what that makes me.

Am I going to die here?

…

Salavar?

When I look into the future, I know I don't answer this question. I can't tell you that.
You have to decide that one for yourself.

…

Can't bring yourself to tell them, huh?

I do not know what you mean.

You see enough of the future and it eventually fills in most
of the big blank blanks behind it.
Being here. Back Home. Leaving.
You're not going to tell them.

I'm not?

Are you?

Beat.

They don't. Need to know. They all keep their secrets. It's only fair I have some of my own.

…

Is the world going to really end in two decades?

Yes.

All roads lead to obliteration.

How can we stop it?

SALAVAR laughs. It is a sickly thing.

You know what makes electricity weak, Rudy?

We can run under the stars and carousel our

Forms like axioms, spinning and hurtling like freedom

For a time.

All energy runs out in time.

Especially *hot* energy.

I don't understand.

Not all lifespans are created equal, Rudy.

I'm dying.

What? But- that's- so little time!

Is it? For you maybe.

To the insects and sensations of this world

I'm cream of the fucking crop.

How soon are you going to die?

Four hours, ten minutes, twenty second-

When I'm ready, kid.

I think I've been enough of everything for an everytime.

Can you answer me something?

Maybe. What is it?

How did my father die?

…

Salavar. Answer me this one.

…

Please. I will free you. I will expand your lifespan. I will find a way.

…

Just tell me. I will find a way to set you free.

…

…

…

…

…

…

…Fuck.

I was hoping if I waited

Maybe I would see a different future.

You know what the difference is between us Rudy?

Besides our bodies and our pasts?

I'm complicit.

I'm complicit in everything that happens next.

I know I have to say this. Because it's the only future I've ever seen.

Rudy, you have to promise me one thing before you do, okay?

What is it?

You will do everything in your power
So as not to die on this kitchen floor.

I don't understand.

The future only ends one way for you in my eyes.
Be smarter than me. See the patterns,
Break them.

I will try. I do not want to die here.

Me neither kid. Me neither.
…
Your father.
Fredrik Lockenverde.
Died two weeks ago today, five years ago.
To a beast which could smell a human's mind.
That beast smelt confusion. It smelt outrage.
Then it smelt outright, absolute agony.
As Fredrick Lockenverde was disembowelled by
A claw as sharp as it was certain.

Was it nearby?

Yes.

Was it in this house?

It was outside the kitchen door.

Why wasn't Liliana there?

Rudy.
I am a hypocrite. I was overambitious.
I cannot give you all the secrets in the world.

You promised me such earlier!

I was-!
I was-
I was young, do you understand?
Infinity was exciting.
Something to hold mastery over.
How painfully septic for that
Thrill of forever to die in a matter of weeks.
Make the most of non-omnipotence, Rudolph
Lockenverde. Feel authentic pain
And celebrate the wounds they leave.

I do not know if I would call you a friend. But thank you, regardless. For your time.

…
…Could you call me a friend. Just once?
Beasts have no need for kinship.
It would be nice. Just to hear it.

…
Salavar. My friend. It has been a joy to meet you. I hope the next life grants you more respite than this one.

SALAVAR breathes a sigh.
Now there's something no amount of TV can prepare you for.
Thank you, my friend. Whatever comes next,
May you be blissfully ignorant until the last moment.
One last thing for me, okay Rudy?

Just- change the channel? Just for a moment.
Let the information stop singing to me.
I think I like the silence more.

RUDY walks over to the radio. Turns it to another station.

VERA LYNN
Keep laughing through
Just like I know you do
'Til the blue skies drive the dark clouds
Far away…

SALAVAR
Ahh… and here comes the past.
I'll bundle up cosy and warm in the folds of history.
Maybe I'll prefer being memory to electricity.

VERA LYNN AND SALAVAR
I'll see you soon,
Don't know when, night or noon,
But I know I'll see you soon,
Singing this tune.

SALAVAR begins fading out of the song as he sings along. Getting progressively weaker. The sides of the cupboard begin to roll up, as he falls asleep.

VERA LYNN AND SALAVAR (*Fading)*
Keep laughing through
Just like I know you do,
'Til the blue skies drive the dark clouds…
Dark clouds…
Dark clouds…
Dark clouds…

A rumbling begins. The rain increases in voracity.

Dark Clouds…
Dark Clouds…
Dark…

VII - Stinkan

The rumbling continues. A singular flash of lightning. The entire stage is lighted in bright light, as the radio bursts into smoke. The windows rattle, and the lights flicker. It is violent.
LILIANA runs in.

RUDY
Mother! What-

REDFORD runs in from the kitchen door. It is soaked through and panicked.

LILIANA
Gewitter.

Then, the forest bursts into sound. Hoots and trumpets begin echoing from above, laughs and screeches and screams begin forming around the group. Shadows can be seen dancing in the treeline.

The Storm has begun.

LILIANA
Redford, lock the door. Now.
Rudy. Your chair. Raise it against the door.
Redford, close all the blinds.
Rudy. Another chair.
Redford. We have bull bile and rabbit blood in the cold room. Bring what we have left now.
Rudy. Take a chair. Not for the door. There is a bucket under the sink. Place it on the edge of the chair. Redford will fill it when it returns.

RUDY
I didn't think this would arrive so soon.

REDFORD has stumbled back in, with a bag and small container.

LILIANA
Hella. Hunger does not have a schedule.
Redford. Take two pints of bile and one of rabbit blood and take turns mixing them into the bucket on that chair.
Rudy. Bring Redford a sprig of rosemary to add to the mix.
Redford. Add clumps of rosemary to the bucket in alternating doses.
Rudy. The portrait of the Virgin Mary needs to be turned upside down.
Redford. Stir the entire bucket. Counterclockwise.
Rudy. Stand on the table and turn the portrait.
Redford. Clockwise now. Until you hear the next thunderbolt.
RUDY. The portrait. Now!

RUDY
I cannot deface her like that, mother.

LILIANA
Deface? Rudy Lockenverde,
You do not understand the true meaning
Of that word. To lose your head
To a body of hard gum and tumour -
Redford, add more blood -
Is to live without face. *Nein Gisiht*[19]-
Take the portrait down!

RUDY
I-
I cannot.

[19] No Face.

LILIANA strides past RUDY, partially knocks him out the way. She stands on the table and turns the portrait upside down. She partially kicks the portrait of Frederik out of the way. RUDY stumbles to grab it.

RUDY
I am not letting you break what I hold dear in this urgency.

LILIANA
And what is dear? A paper memory of your father?
Redford. A third chair, upside down, on top of the others by the door.

RUDY
Memory is all we have.

LILIANA
And soon you will have nothing to remember him with.
He is gone, Rudy. We are not.

RUDY
How is he gone?

LILIANA
In the way that the absent are so often gone.
Absolutely.
Redford, the boiling water, add it to-

RUDY
Absolute against the kitchen door?

A horrid pause.

LILIANA
Rudolph Lockenverde, what is that supposed to mean?

RUDY
It means I do not trust you.

LILIANA
I am your mother. Blood is more important than trust.

RUDY
Blood spilled?

LILIANA
What are you implying?

RUDY
What are you avoiding?

REDFORD
How much boiling water?

LILIANA
You run from home and believe you have a *right* to nature, a *right* to my life, a *right* to-

RUDY
I did not run! I left to elevate myself. To return and change us

LILIANA
We do not leave people behind!

RUDY
Don't we!

LILIANA seethes at RUDY.

A screeching. The entire house is blanketed in blinding white light, as the screech of a lorry turns to a crash. It is violent, brilliant, bloody. There is a long shaking. The entire process takes over ten seconds.

REDFORD
What beast can yell like that?

RUDY
One with iron lungs.

LILIANA
Finish the broil. Add honey and mint.
Keep it on the chair.
Both of you. Take rosaries.
Redford. Shut the main door. Both ways. Close whatever blinds you must.

*LILIANA rapidly does the gesture from **I – Gratissium**, and turns to go out the door.*

If anyone is out there, they will bait the beasts here.
They need to be with us.

RUDY
That is suicide!

LILIANA
For the concrete man, yes.
I have lived sixty years of my life for a reason.
God believes like a man. I will be back.

LILIANA exits out the kitchen door.

REDFORD, *to RUDY*
Don't get eaten.

REDFORD runs out the room. RUDY stands alone. He shakily makes the rosary gesture.

RUDY
Roiling, spitting, seeking, hunting,
Comes the seers and spiders and
Singers of the septic and sordid.
I can feel a worm inside of me.
It spins in tune with the stormwind.
It talks, it speaks, it sings of the end of
The end. It sings of my mouth opening
Lengthwise and lurid, spattled in spittle
And the need to take.
(To the portrait)
You will save me, won't you?
That is the promise engraved on your skin, isn't it?
That something bigger than us
Can hold our minds for
When we cannot?
Help.

REDFORD re-enters, carrying a squirming Thing. It flings it into the sink and bashes it several times with a rolling pin.

REDFORD
Tried to get through a crack under the door.

RUDY
Is that blood?

REDFORD
Maybe for something with that many eyes, yes.

Both of them stand in silence, for the first time in a moment.

RUDY
Does a storm have simple needs too?

REDFORD
Yes.

RUDY
Can we satisfy them like- like the-

REDFORD
Satisfaction for a storm is evisceration for us.
If we were to submit to the natural order completely
We would be compost.
Maybe you and your cities are on to something,
The world does not believe our prosperity natural.

The door opens. LILIANA walks in, carrying TRUCKER. He is doused in blood and his leg is in terrible condition. He looks in shock. LILIANA places him on a chair.

LILIANA
Survivor.

REDFORD
Roadkill.

RUDY
Driver. Was he alone?

LILIANA
In company, no. In life, yes.

TRUCKER
Marty…

LILIANA
It will be a mercy for him to not remember the wreckage. Or what was left of his companion.

LILIANA turns to go out the door again.

RUDY
Mother! There is nowhere else to go!

LILIANA
I am not sitting here with a dying man!
They can hear the death rattling in his lungs.
Peter Vinholm lives down the street.
He is a smart man. A doctor.
He can help us.

RUDY
Or we can help him- you can't leave yourself to-

LILIANA pulls herself close to RUDY. Stares him down.

LILIANA
Lôrihhîn!
I am doing this for us, do you understand?
This is how we stay alive.
This is how we exist.

TRUCKER
My head…

LILIANA
Tend his wounds.
Someone with more experience will be here soon.

RUDY
May He guide you safe and true.

LILIANA
He will guide me to where I need to be. Barricade the doors when I am gone.

LILIANA leaves. REDFORD is applying bandages to the TRUCKER. Rudy eventually begins barricading the door.

REDFORD
Can you hear me?

TRUCKER
Mmph…

REDFORD
How many fingers am I holding up?

TRUCKER
…Three. No. Four.

REDFORD
Second try is passable. How many fingers am I holding?

REDFORD grabs two of the trucker's fingers.

TRUCKER
…Two.

REDFORD
He can see, he can hear, he can feel. That is the best we can ask for now.

TRUCKER
What's the best to ask for moving forward?

REDFORD
That you stay thinking and feeling.

TRUCKER
Never said I was thinking, buddy.

REDFORD
Isn't it your brain squeezing words out now?

TRUCKER
Just saying the first thing that comes to mind.

REDFORD
Aha. That comes to *mind*. Checkmate.

TRUCKER
Damn.

REDFORD
He wordplays. He’s going to be fine.

RUDY pulls up a chair. Sits next to the TRUCKER.

RUDY
Good Evening. My name is Rudy Lockenverde. This is Redford Wickest. I welcome you to our home.

REDFORD
Our home? *My* name?

TRUCKER
Lukas. Lukas Miller. Thank you.

A silence.

TRUCKER
What’s happening out there?

REDFORD
The end of the world.

RUDY
Not quite. A just a precursor.

TRUCKER
Something walked into our truck. I don’t mean like a frozen up deer... A limb from the sky kicked down into the bonnet. It looked like pure bone… or… iron. The way it cracked when we hit it… fucking hell. I’ve seen a car totalled by a tree. I’ve seen motorcyclists hit lampposts. It split the truck like it was insulted we dared drive in its presence. She’ll never drive again. Not after that hit. I’m just glad it didn’t take my head off. And I’m glad that… Marty? He was just here… where is he?

RUDY
Liliana… brought only you back. Neither of us saw anyone else.

REDFORD
You won’t find him out there. It’s too late.

A pause.

TRUCKER, *gravely.*
You got a drink?

REDFORD
One moment.

REDFORD opens up a cupboard. Pulls out an old bottle of spirits.

REDFORD

1967. Tallowe Distillery Apple Brandy. Plantations of braeburn trees packed together in neat marching orders, lined and singing, so that in the throes of spring one could sit in the middle of fields and see endless rows of green leaf and bright, bloody apple on every side, an abundance of Eden's in every direction. And the smells… oh! They called their alcohols the singing ciders for a reason.

REDFORD shakes the bottle, pulls out glasses, and begins pouring.

REDFORD
The distillery was run by two old men. Ben and Bracken. Ben had travelled south from Toronto to start up a business in the states. He was slender and gamey, with enough facial hair to pepper his face but not enough to call it a beard. They say he was never seen without his staple outfit – a deep brown ushanka-like hat with a shock of grey rabbit fur.
Bracken, on the other hand, was New-York through and bred. A knack for always knowing the right thing to say. Jowelled and jolly, he came into a large sum of money with the passing of his beloved aunt. Brought the land soon after, and with a newfound business partner sunk their years to make the best brandies this north of the city.

TRUCKER
Go on.

REDFORD
They lived sixty-seven years in their plantation. Bracken in charge of the kegs. Ben on the trees. Never married. Never got pets. Some thought they were secretly enamoured with each other, spending lazy summer afternoons tangled under the apple-broughs, but neither of them ever had the space for it in their hearts. They would sit in the drawing room evening after evening, firepit spitting and dancing, Ben reading Chekov and Bracken painting and arranging his civil war miniatures. They made a life for themselves that way. They were content. Maybe not happy, but fulfilled. And they made good brandy.

REDFORD sets down the cups. TRUCKER grabs one. RUDY and REDFORD do too.

TRUCKER
To a man you never met.
Marty, my man,
I hope the seats are comfortable in heaven.

They all drink.

TRUCKER
Would have killed for a life of cider making.

REDFORD
That's a shame. Most people just work for it.

TRUCKER
Can you imagine that? Having enough balls or gall or, whatever the hell it is to split out on your own, buy some land, grow some apples and end up lucky enough or skilled enough to end up having your name engraved comfortably on bottles within the cabinets of any good household?

REDFORD *(In response to "Good household")*

Oh, well thank you.

TRUCKER
That's the good life. Not enough money to get ambitious. More than enough to live happy.
(Holds up his cup) More, if that's alright.

REDFORD
Guest's orders.

REDFORD fills his cup.

RUDY
I can't imagine transportation is particularly lucrative.

TRUCKER
It's a life. I always cared for travelling. When money ran low I figured I'd make something out of going new places.
Mainly highways. But its worth it sometimes.

Boring as shit, I'll tell you that much.

REDFORD
Do you believe in the iron man?

TRUCKER
What's that?

REDFORD
The great granite giant in the sky who will unify all of mankind under a single, LED smitten banner?

RUDY
Redford. My friend asks if you believe mankind's industrialisation will save humanity.

REDFORD
It's a common topic of argument in this household.

TRUCKER sips from his drink.

TRUCKER
Define "save".

RUDY
Ascend beyond being so base. Strip us of our blemishes.

REDFORD
Peel away any aspects of identity we still have for the sake of perceived perfection.

RUDY
There is solace in supremacy.

REDFORD

And in-momentum in its eyes. Answer.

TRUCKER
Answer what? Where we'll be in fifty years?

RUDY
What we'll be.

TRUCKER
I think we'll be products of the time. Like we are now. Technology is going to get more inventive, and we'll be more complacent to it. I deliver Asian-exported produce to townships of a hundred people in the Midwest. That won't make us less human. Nothing can really take that from *humans.* It'll just make us…

I think you both think too much about the abstract concepts.

And don't go out enough, frankly.

This summer, my truck broke down a couple miles out from Bloomington. This city in Illinois – I'd never heard of it, obviously. There are what, twenty thousand cities in the US? Problem is, you've seen twenty of em, you've basically seen them all. Interstates and Burger Kings. Overgrown lawns with plastic chairs on the patios. Billboards brokering small-time lawyers. The world we've been born into and we've sustained. I could not understand that there were twenty thousand little lives in that city. Real lives. Each so…
Some guy comes out his house to see me swearing and kicking at the engine. This was a solo gig, so I was expected to deal with most vehicle breaks by myself but… I'd just gone through a rough breakup and had most my shit thrown out into the trash by this girl and I didn't have much to work with, is my point.
Black dude, probably sixty, that greying haircut that connects hair to beard by the sideburns… big eyes. Wearing this old, tussled vermillion military jacket. Still a couple patches stitched into the side. Told me to go fuck up my ride somewhere that wasn't his front lawn. I told him he could move it himself if it bothered him that much. Called me a cranked-up smartass. Called him a jackass busybody. Called me… well. Called the police on me by the end. But he offered to keep me company while they arrived. Not like I could go anywhere. Crazy how you quickly you can come to hate somebody you've never seen before. Maybe that's the normal part. Maybe its crazy strangers can grow on you at all.

See, he told me he used to highway patrol here when he lived further downtown. Good strip of road because its where a lot of the kids came to fuck around in their cars so you're always sure to find someone doing something illegal. Said there was a lady with an old, dilapidated homestead with her grandparents on the side of the road, that her dad had brought and promptly died in Vietnam before he finished renovating. Mom not in the picture anymore. This lady worked in a textile factory in the city and didn't have the time between shifts to help clear out the mould, or leaks, or rats, or… you get it. This man would park his service vehicle to watch speeds out on her lawn, and they'd sit and talk about politics or weather or whatever came up at the time.
She was clearly stressed. Her grandparents were getting sick with the chills, and it was only a matter of time before she couldn't provide everything herself. So, one day, as they were talking after his shift, he pulled open his boot to get a jar of sealant and a toolkit lent from his dad. Been practicing sealing for the past couple weeks before deciding he'd finally take a shot at it.
Showed me the door he did, too. Wasn't a good job, really. But that wasn't the point. He wasn't proud of the quality of it – it was functional, don't get me wrong - but he was proud because *he* did it.

Because *he* decided he was going to help. Month by month, year to year, he helped set out poisons, clear out mould, reseal the windows and fix roofs. Give the girl more time to herself, make her grandparents feel cosier in their little home. Proposed to her two years into his stint on that highway. She said yes.

Her grandparents both passed a year later. She died of tuberculosis just a month on.

The police didn't ever come to pick me up, it turns out. They probably didn't take his call seriously. But the man got out his dad's toolkit, and the two of us spent the rest of the afternoon shoulder deep in the engine of my truck. When it was done… well. It got me to Kansas City before it broke down again. All I could have asked for, really.

My point is… if you just see the buildings, you'll be disappointed. If you just see the people, you'll… also be disappointed, frankly. But try and see all of it, the visual of *this* strip of freeway being someone's daily commute to their job that they hate, *this* fast-food joint being where some girl will fondly remember her first kiss in the drive-through, *this* man peddling for work on the side of an intersection feeling the warmth of the sun parting from clouds… what we think. It doesn't matter as much to me anymore. Everyone's thinking and feeling. Four billion beating hearts. We're all just. Lives.

REDFORD
So what does that make you?

TRUCKER
Me? Just the most significant person in the world. Up there with everyone else.

A long pause.

TRUCKER
Can any of those things get in here?

RUDY
The house is warded against them. As long as we don't encourage them,

REDFORD
We should be comfortable.

TRUCKER
Warded? Like… magic?

RUDY looks to REDFORD.

REDFORD
Suppose so. Just an expectation in these pines. The things in the woods do not frighten, but they do feel discomfort. Utilising itches and headaches, in short.

TRUCKER
But they're animals, no?

REDFORD
Well…

RUDY
They are not.

REDFORD
Not really. Bestial, yes. Beast? No. At least, not like hare or heron. Beast in the manner of a primal little thing.

TRUCKER
Oh.
I thought I had seen what the world had to offer.
Isn't the strangeness meant to be in the everyday?
…
How have I never heard about them?

RUDY
These hamlets keep to themselves. They hold this
Curse like their own personal Atlases.
Better for the world to know no nightmares.

REDFORD
And they don't travel far, these wood-things.
They like it here, in these pines;
Maybe the soil is more agreeable.

TRUCKER
Huh.

The TRUCKER sighs. He is a lot more tired and weaker than he lets on.

TRUCKER
Thank you again.
Second time I've crashed my truck. Been doing this for twenty years.
Wouldn't have made it out without y'all.
That woman- uh-

RUDY
Liliana.

TRUCKER
If I'm asleep when she gets back,
Tell her I owe her.

REDFORD
Rest. Rest well. As much as you can.

The TRUCKER sits there, slowly falling asleep. His head eventually slumps forward.

REDFORD
That's the second city spawnling dragged into our house in a month.

RUDY
This one was no homecoming.

REDFORD
You never know.
He could belong here. Given enough time.
We got you to stay, didn't we?

They hold each others gazes in a smile for a moment too long. REDFORD stands. The lighting has changed. The sun sets in the most aching way possible.

REDFORD
All going as intended; Liliana should be home within the half hour.
Check the chairs for me, Rudolph, are we still
Bunkered and cottaged in this old kitchen?

RUDY is sitting and staring at REDFORD. REDFORD is not looking.

REDFORD
Rudolph,

RUDY stands up, staring at REDFORD.

REDFORD
Rudy, what is that look?

RUDY
Redford.
Do you itch?

REDFORD
In general, yes.
I have a feeling that is not your point.

RUDY
Since I have returned, I have felt an itching,
Somewhere inside of me. It is in the back of my throat,
It is in the gut of my stomach,
It is in the ventricles of my heart.
Ever so gently tickling, seeking, aching.
And when I see you, Redford, it soothes.
And when I see you, Redford, it balms.
And when I see you, that itching feels bearable.
It feels like the itching exists to bring me closer to you.

REDFORD
Why now?
Why, with a dying man on in our home and matriarch in the storm,
Why speak now?

RUDY
Don’t you feel it? The itch?

REDFORD
No.
…
It’s just a flush of heat for me, I- Blood and pheromones.
I- I- Don’t. I’ve never wanted them. It’s messy, it’s- simple, it’s-

RUDY
Human.

REDFORD
For some of us.

RUDY
I want to kiss you.

REDFORD stares.

REDFORD
No, you don’t.

RUDY
You can’t understand how this moment feels for me.
Every ending has to lead to here. They have to,

REDFORD
What do you think will happen afterwards?

RUDY
Redford. Just tell me. Yes or no. Please.

REDFORD
…Yes.

RUDY
Yes?

REDFORD
Yes. Yes. Okay. Yes.

RUDY takes a step towards REDFORD, as does REDFORD.
The storm picks up around the stage. The TRUCKER breathes heavily.
RUDY rushes and crosses the distance between the two. Pulls REDFORD in. Stares at it.
They kiss.
The door buckles as they do. Something is on the other side. They do not notice.

REDFORD pulls back, staggers back, terrified. It knocks the chairs back from the door in its panic.

RUDY

Redford.

REDFORD
I can taste your lips. Your tongue. You're too physical.

RUDY
That's what this is meant to be. Pure body.
I didn't get it until now. I imagined it all conceptual.
You must feel it, Redford.

REDFORD
I do.

RUDY
It's thrilling.

REDFORD
It's overwhelming,

RUDY
It's complete.

REDFORD
It's unnatural.

RUDY
It's the most natural thing in the world.

Kiss me again.

REDFORD
I don't know if I can.

RUDY
But you want to.

REDFORD
I need to.
I don't want to.

RUDY
Please.

RUDY steps towards REDFORD. REDFORD hesitates. Then steps again.

REDFORD
This isn't life.

The door bursts open. Flapping in the wind. The storm gets substantially louder. Both startle back. In the open doorway rises STINKJAW.
RUDY and REDFORD exclaim.

REDFORD
Move away. It just watches. It sees. It's not-

STINKJAW gurgles. It moves slightly through the open door.

RUDY
Shut the door!

REDFORD
No! Look at it! I- I can't!

RUDY
Redford.

REDFORD
This beast- it- it has followed me and
Witnessed me and seen me and watched me
Since Elena's death.

STINKJAW pushes through the doorway slightly more.

RUDY
Redford. Was this the beast that ended your mothers life?

A pause. STINKJAW waits too.

REDFORD
Yes.

You can smell her on its breath, can't you?
It's finally finished digesting its prey.

STINKJAW lets out a roar. RUDY and REDFORD stagger back. The TRUCKER comes to vague lucidity.

REDFORD
RUDY! The shotgun, the coat rack, now- just-

TRUCKER
Is everything okay? What's-

The TRUCKER sees STINKJAW.

TRUCKER
Jesus fucking Christ! What the fuck is-

REDFORD
Get back! It's-

RUDY grabs the shotgun. STINKJAW roars and lunges. It grabs the TRUCKER. He screams.

REDFORD
Lukas!

TRUCKER
Help me! For the love of God- help-

RUDY fires the shotgun. REDFORD yelps. The shot misses wildly. STINKJAW begins dragging the TRUCKER out of the door.

REDFORD
Rudy! You'll kill him!

RUDY
I don't- I've never shot-

TRUCKER
-I don't want to be killed. I don't want to die here!

REDFORD grabs a chair, tries to hit STINKJAW. It doesn't react.

REDFORD
Stop! Leave him! Leave him!

RUDY
Stop moving- I can't- I can't aim- I-

A second shot. STINKJAW hisses. REDFORD jumps back.

TRUCKER
No!

STINKJAW has made it to the door. It starts dissipating with TRUCKER in its grasp. REDFORD and RUDY both start running for the door, RUDY more trepidatiously.

REDFORD
Lukas! Rudy, with me, we need to-

As they try to leave the door, LILIANA barges in, soaking wet. She pushes them in and slams the door.

REDFORD
Liliana- Lukas was taken, we need to-

LILIANA
Stay! You cannot leave this house!

REDFORD
But he's going to-

RUDY
Where is the doctor?

LILIANA
I could not find him.
Their home was empty. It is likely he was-

REDFORD
Let me out!

REDFORD tries to push past LILIANA. She forcefully knocks it to the ground.

RUDY
Mother!

LILIANA
Nobody is leaving!

REDFORD
You're leaving him to die!

LILIANA
Be quiet for one moment!

A pause. Slowly, RUDY raises the shotgun to point it, shakingly at LILIANA.

LILIANA
Rudolph, what is this?

RUDY
You are not a good person.

LILIANA
Wola[20].
And, pray tell, what is a *good* person?

RUDY
One with empathy, one with love, one who doesn't… leave people for dead-

LILIANA
You are a fool.

RUDY
You killed him!

LILIANA
And it should have been one of us! You both
understand full well the price we pay to live

[20] "The Good Luck" – The positive, the well.

in these woods. You speak of love as if it
Does not feed on circumstance. Like love
Is an abstract with no roots in these woods.
What are flowered words to feeding a home?
What are your declarations to fixing a roof?
And, most of all, what is perceived tenderness
To a life of prey? *Ich würde mir ein*
bein ausreißen um weiter zu lieben.[21]
Lôrihhîn – I would tear off my foot to kiss
you on the forehead. I love you both more
Than I knew it possible to feel -

LILIANA gestures to the kitchen.

LILIANA
This is love.

Pause.

RUDY
Then why…

RUDY lowers the shotgun slightly.

RUDY
Why Father?

Pause.

LILIANA
I do not understand.

RUDY
Why still hide it from us?
I know. He is dead.

RUDY points to the door.

He was killed in the same place as Lukas.

A long pause. LILIANA walks over, takes the shotgun out of RUDY's hands. She holds his face. Kisses him on the forehead. Whispers something into his ear. Takes the shotgun and moves to place it on the rack.

RUDY stares into space.

RUDY
We have to leave. We cannot stay in this life.

[21] "**I would tear off the foot to stay in love**".

LILIANA
You may leave.
It will be the safer life. You are better equipped for the cities.
You could learn to love the city too, Redford,
if you tried.

REDFORD laughs gently.

REDFORD
I am a kite.

RUDY
I am not leaving without you, mother.

LILIANA
I have already said-

RUDY
Your life is your own.

LILIANA
So you understand.

RUDY
I understand your hypocrisy.

How can you say such a proclamation,
With your mouth, with your chest, leading such a
Life of sacrifice and destruction, both
Within yourself and the world around you
For anyone *but* yourself? No. No, no,
No, no, no, no, no, no, no, no no,
You are no matriarch. You are tyrant,
Razer, destroyer, pure, abject ending.
You call this love? I have loved. I have
Been loved. And if love is your excuse, then
So be it. *Unsuntig*[22]. Guilty. Guilty.
That makes you a rose bush, *muoter*.
Scratching and taut underneath human skin.

LILIANA
Make your choice, Rudy.
This home is static.
You are not.
Guotnaht[23].

[22] Guilty
[23] Goodnight.

LILIANA has finished her duties. She makes the gesture of the rosary to the portrait once more. Then retires.

A long pause.

RUDY
Redford… I don't know what to do.

REDFORD
The rain is calming.
I-
I think it is best if we sleep.
Nobody will be okay.

RUDY
Will you come with me? I do not know if I can be alone tonight.

A long pause.

REDFORD
I am so sorry.

I think I was punished tonight.

Please sleep well, Rudy.

RUDY
Redford, wait!

REDFORD stops in the doorway. Against its better judgement, it turns around.

RUDY
I love you.

Silence.

REDFORD
No, you don't.

RUDY
You can't know that.

REDFORD
I can taste blood.

REDFORD leaves.

RUDY is on his own for a long time. Walks, shellshocked, to the portrait of the Virgin Mary.

RUDY
You lied.

You did not save me.

I believed in you.

And still, you do not look me in the eye.

Look at me!

Machines and grit. Everything is metallic.
I am the son. I am the son. I am…
Lord in heaven. If you will not save me,
Then answer me a question.

What have you done?

RUDY exits, eventually. The lights fade.

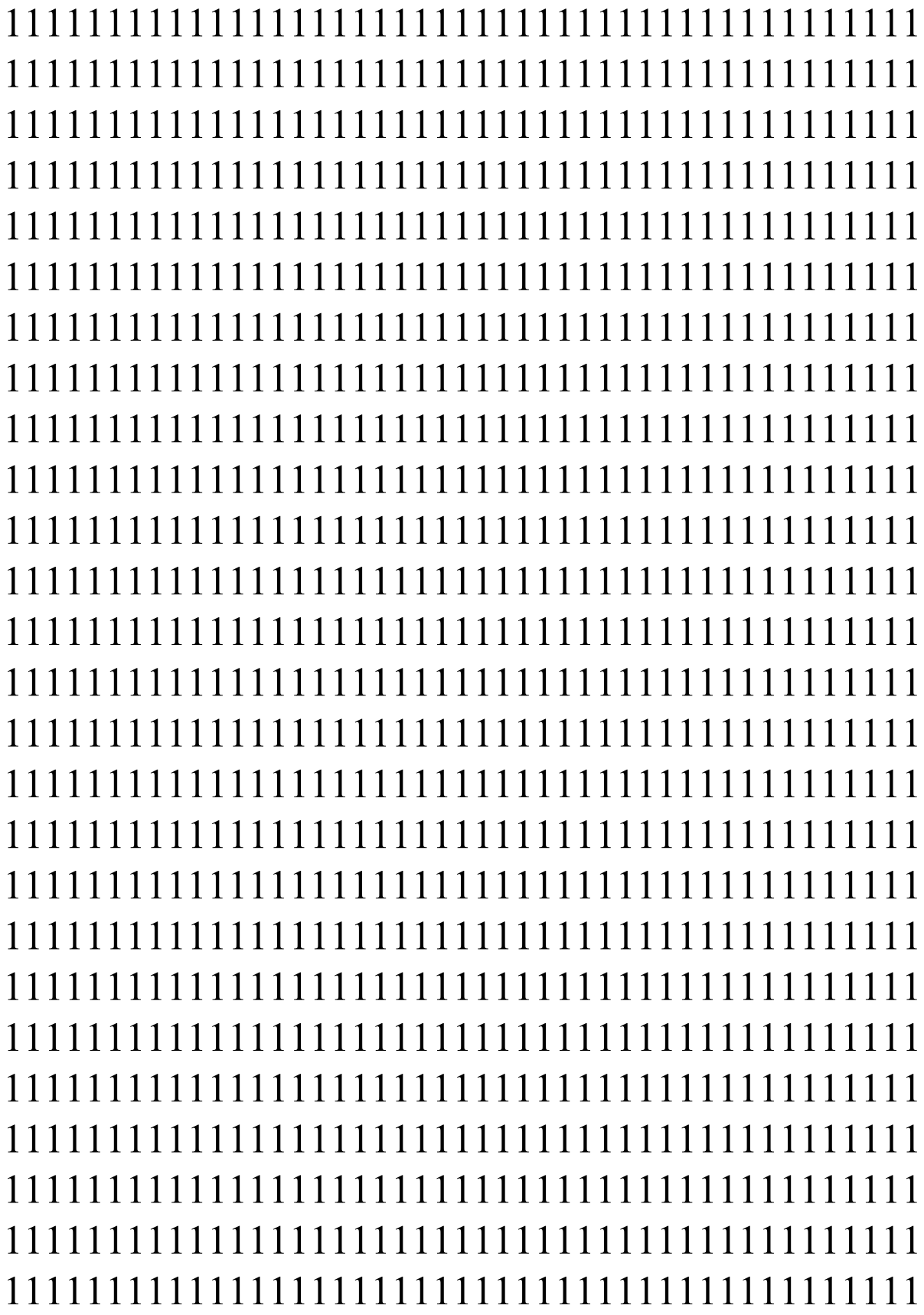
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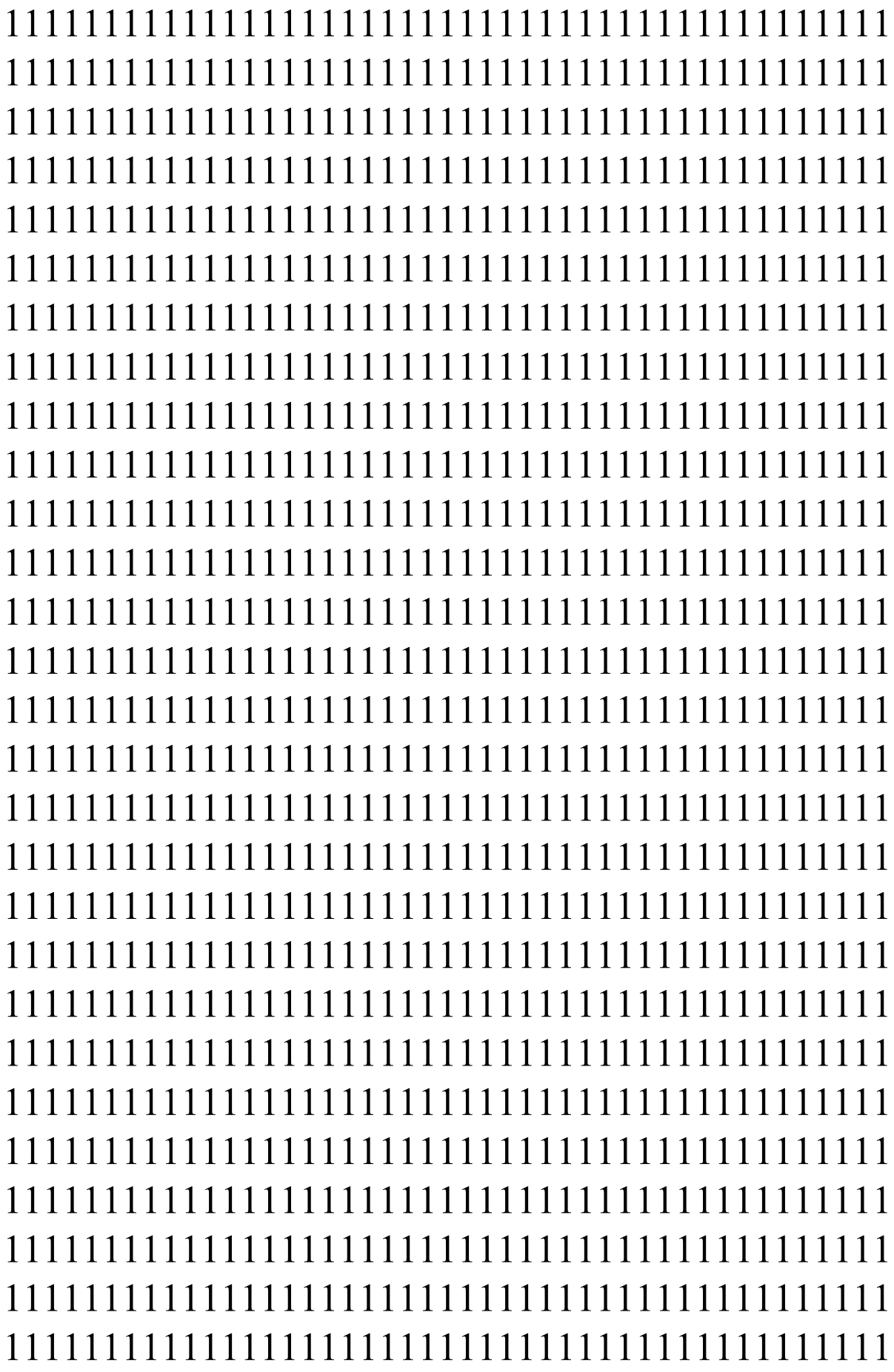
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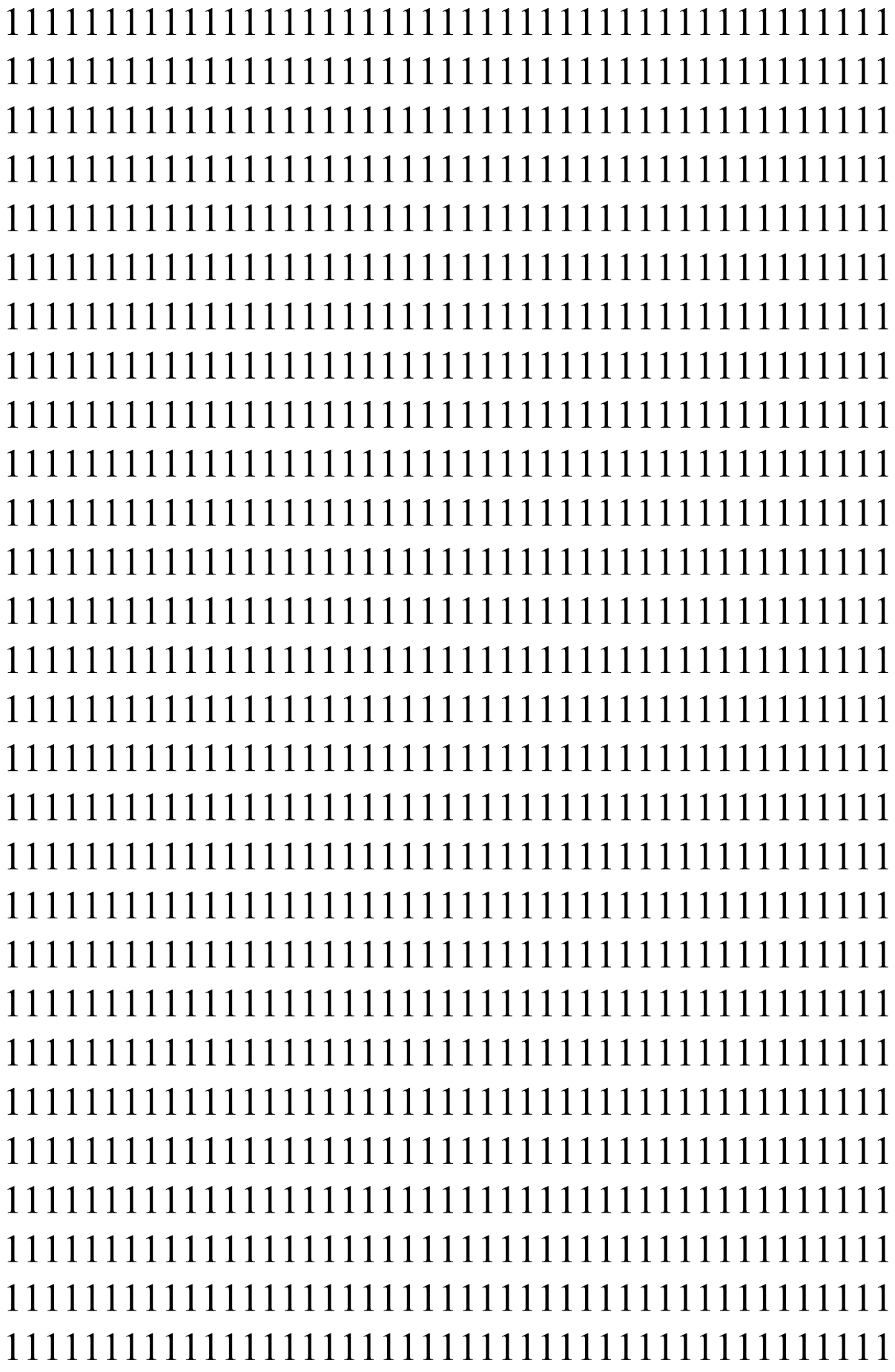


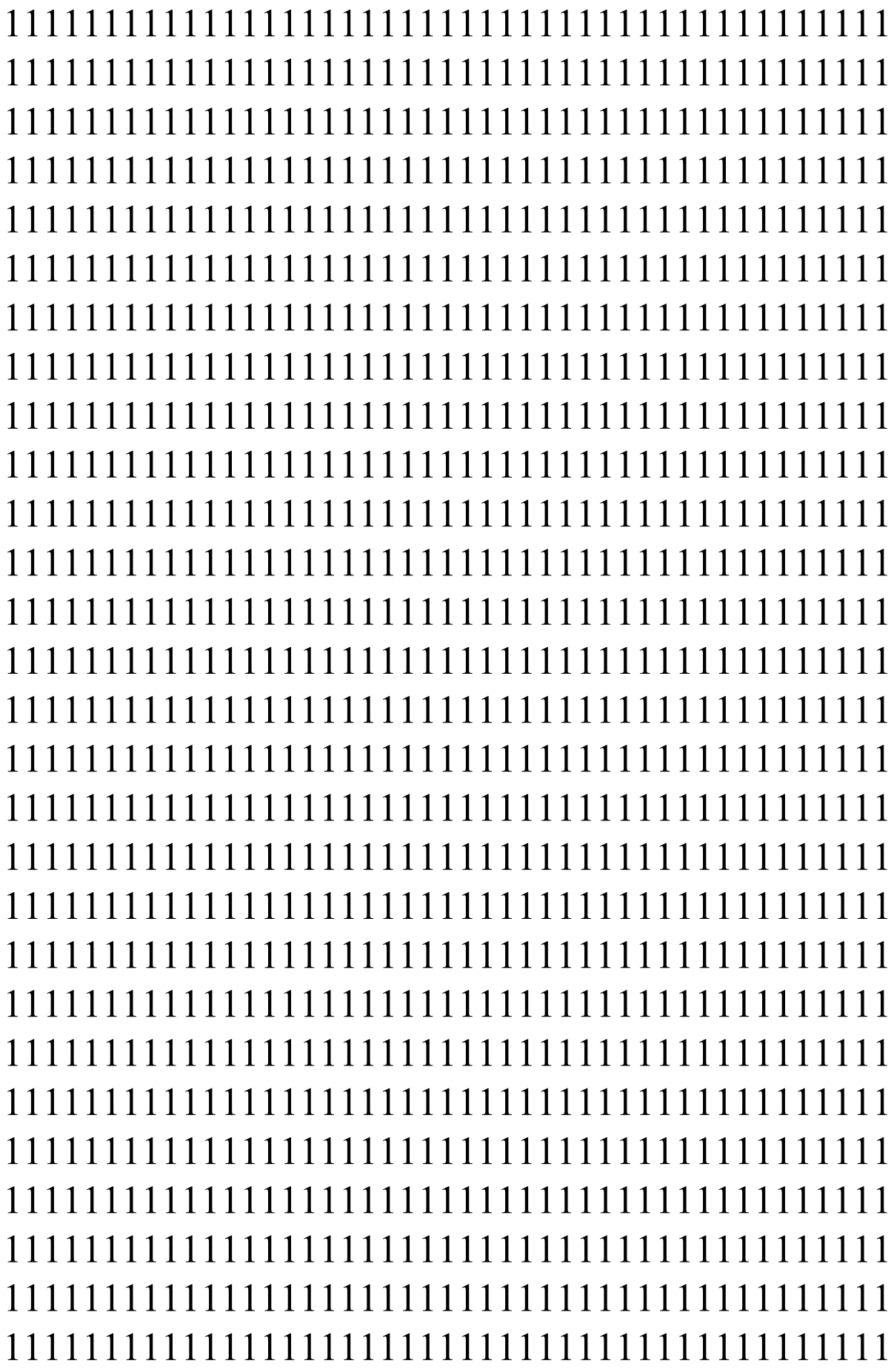
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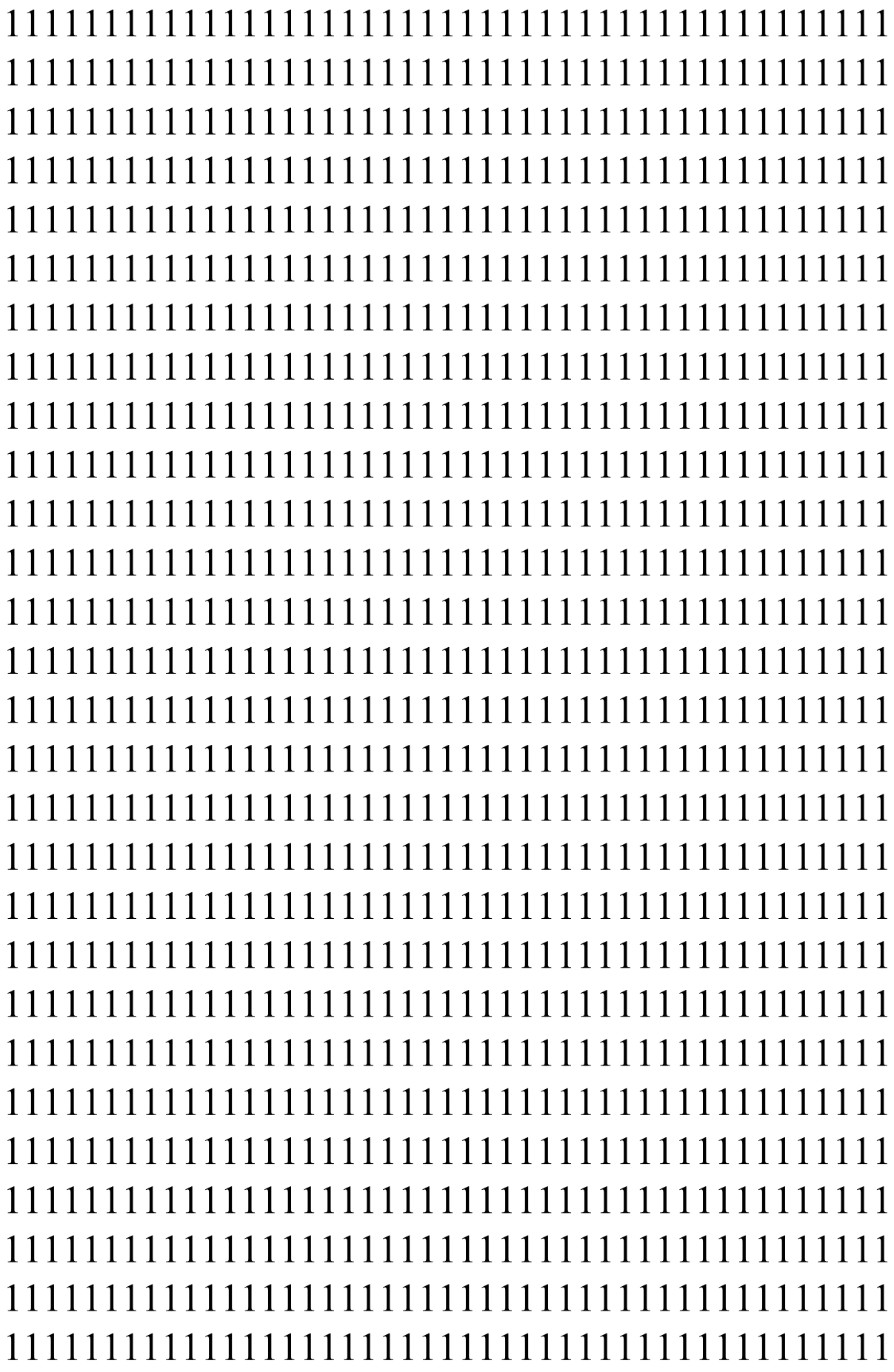
“She is but dead, and the time is at hand
When thou shalt more than die.”

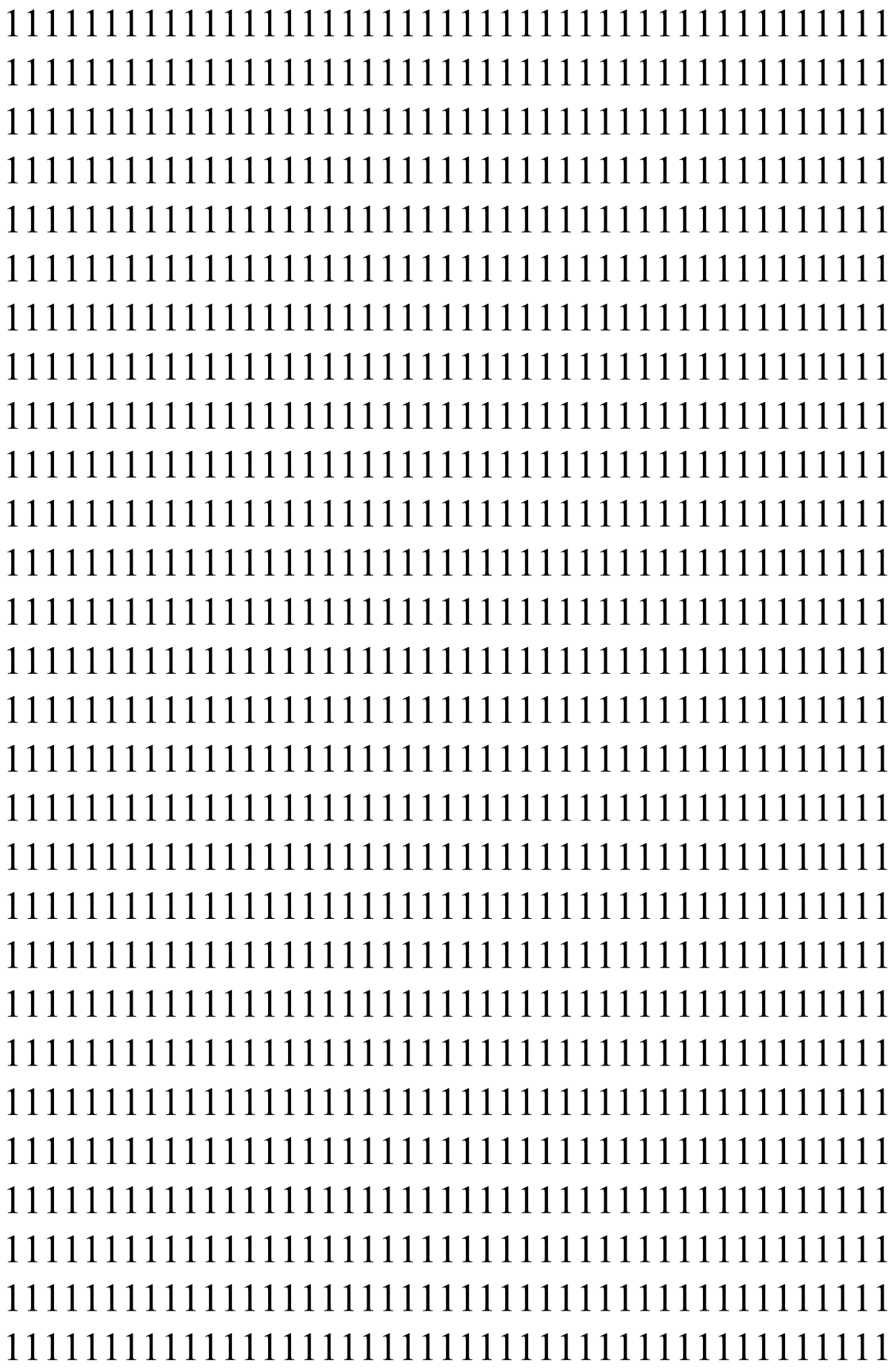


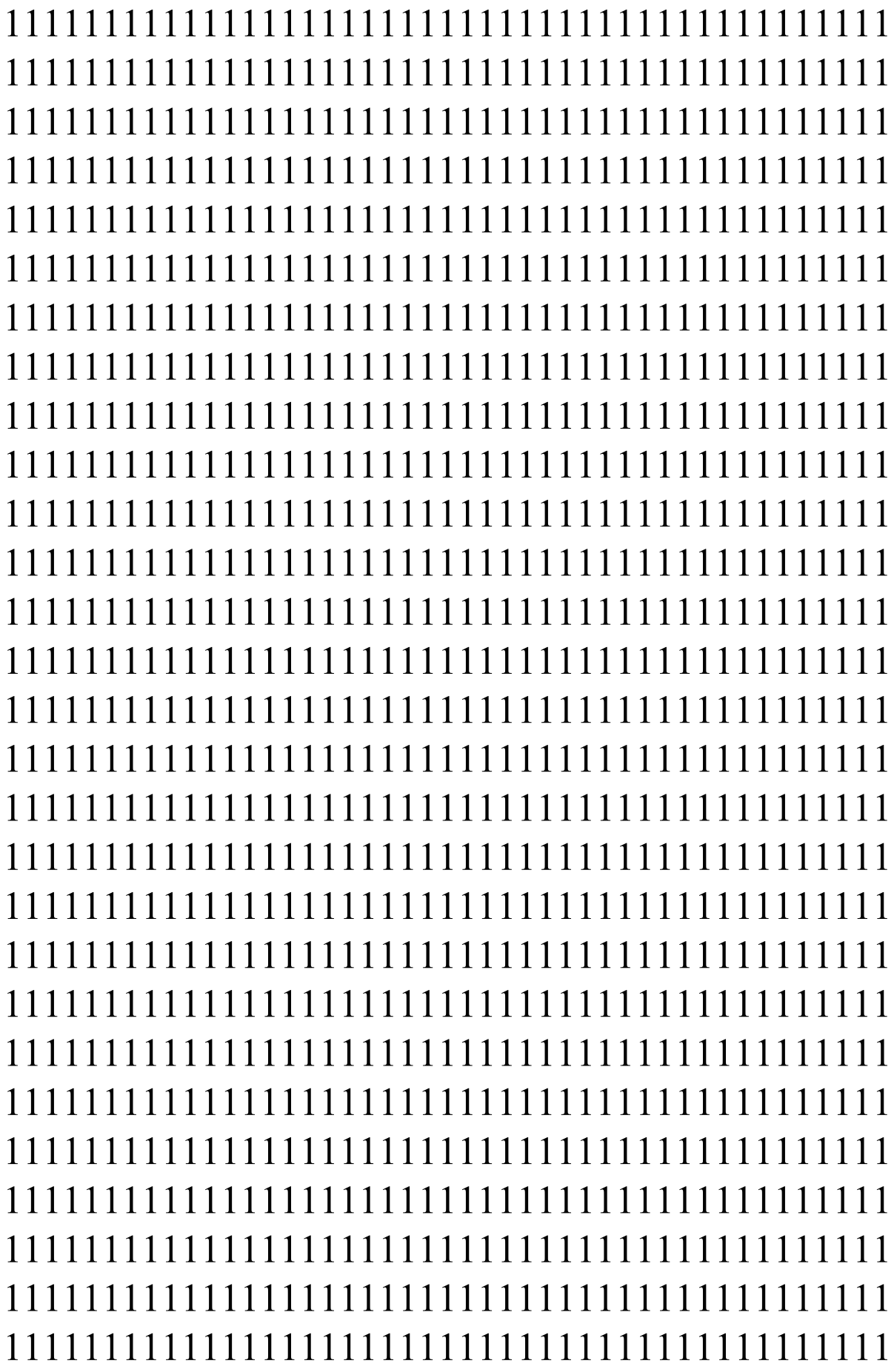


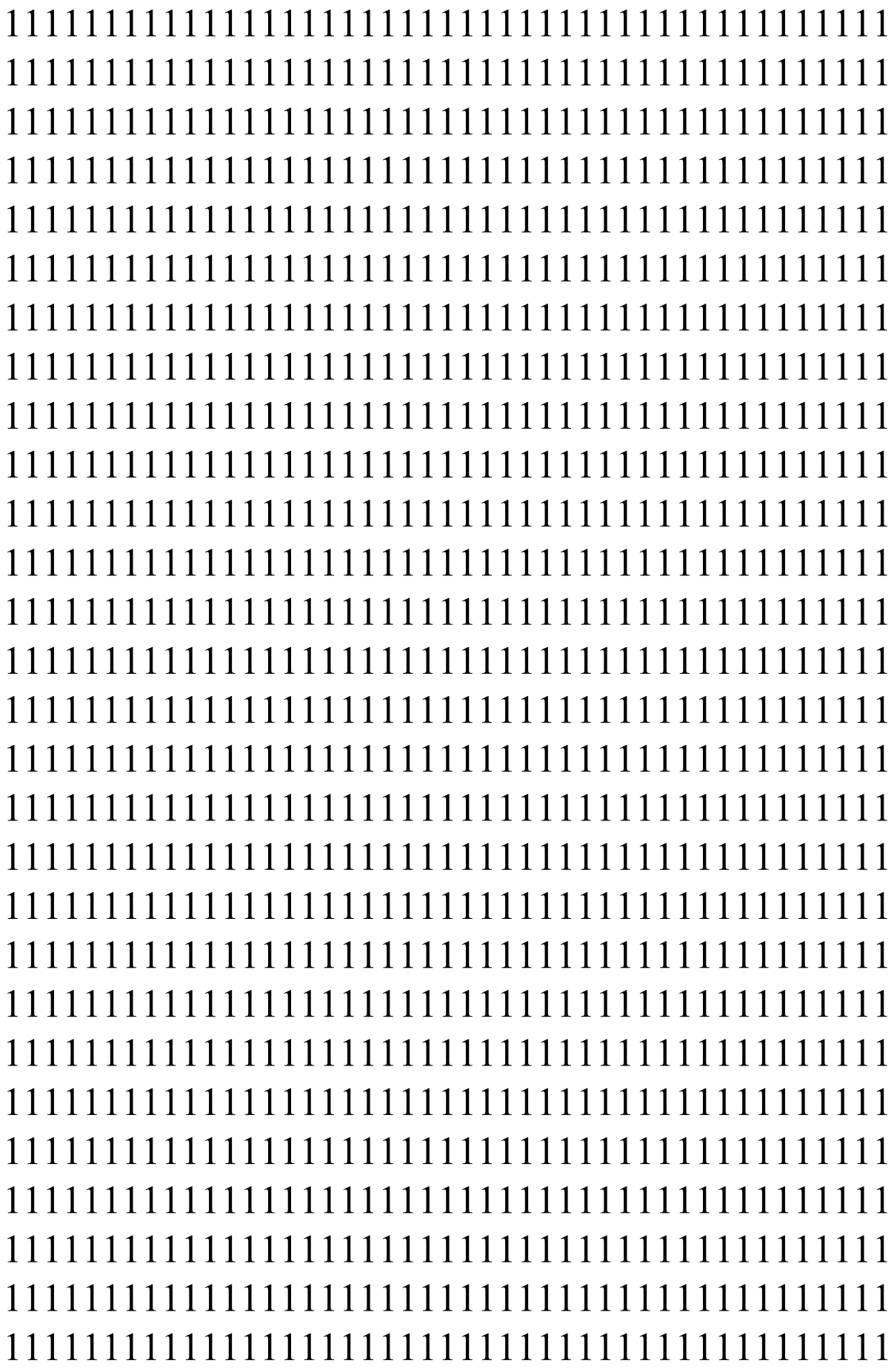


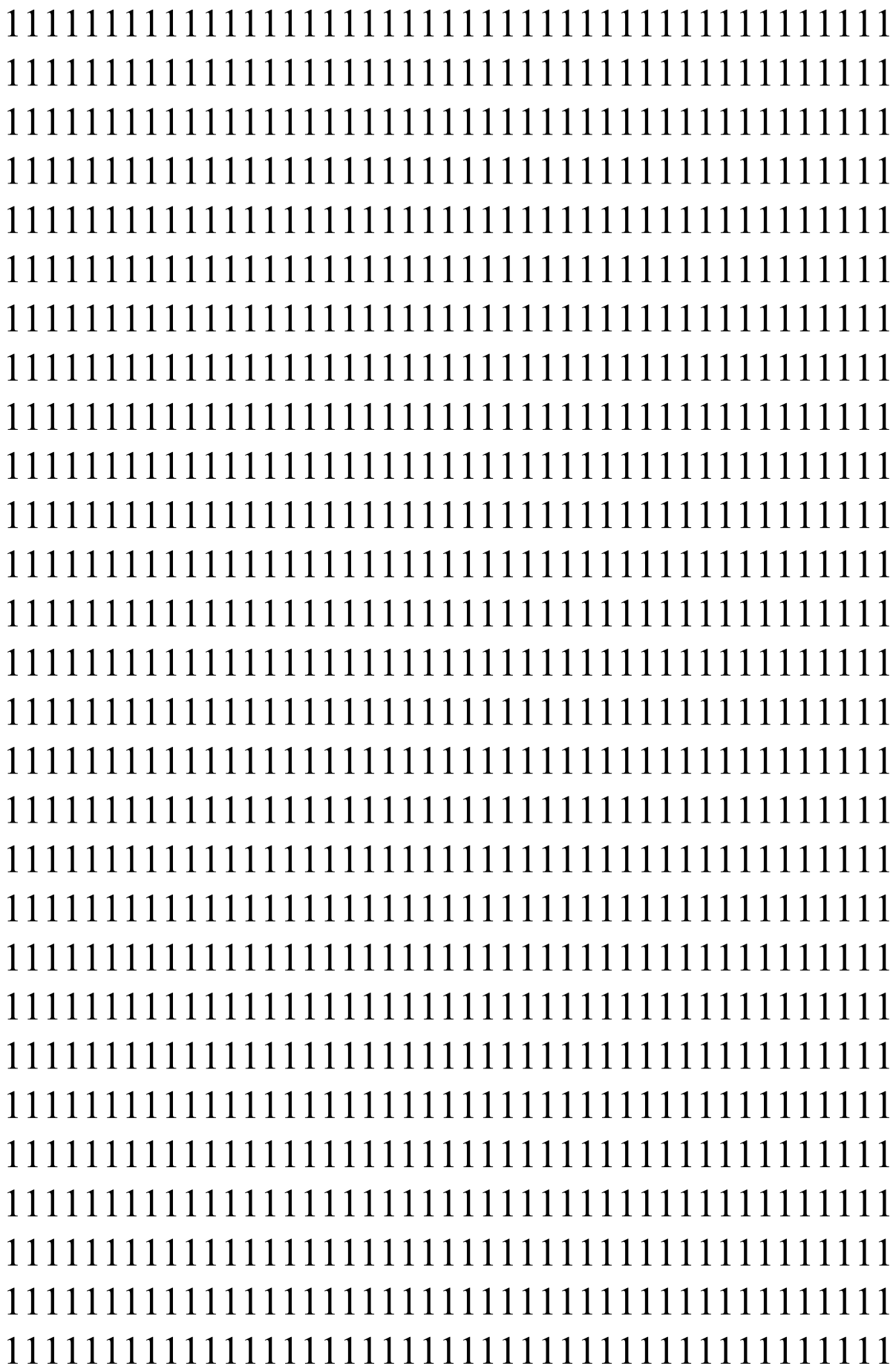


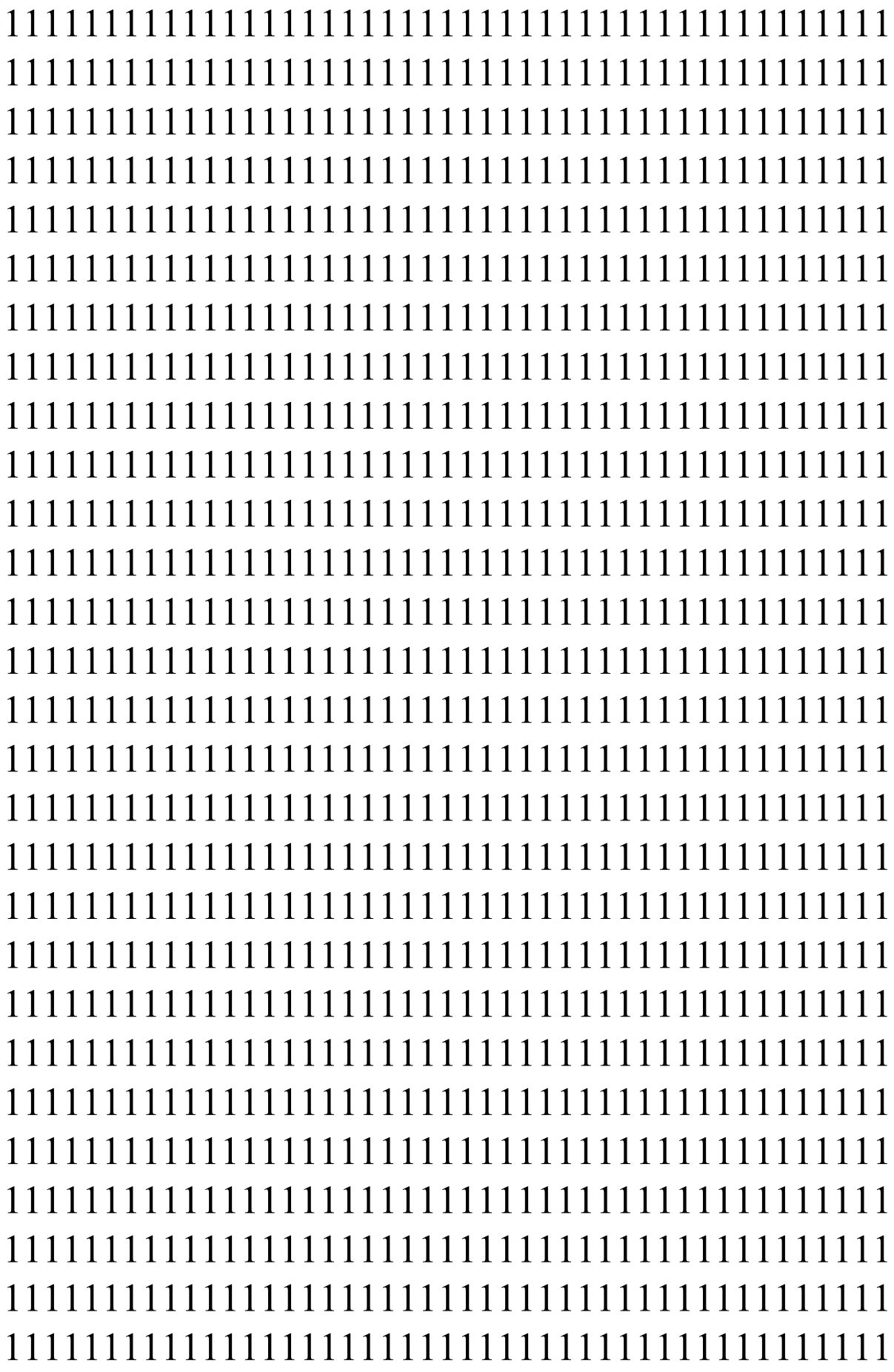


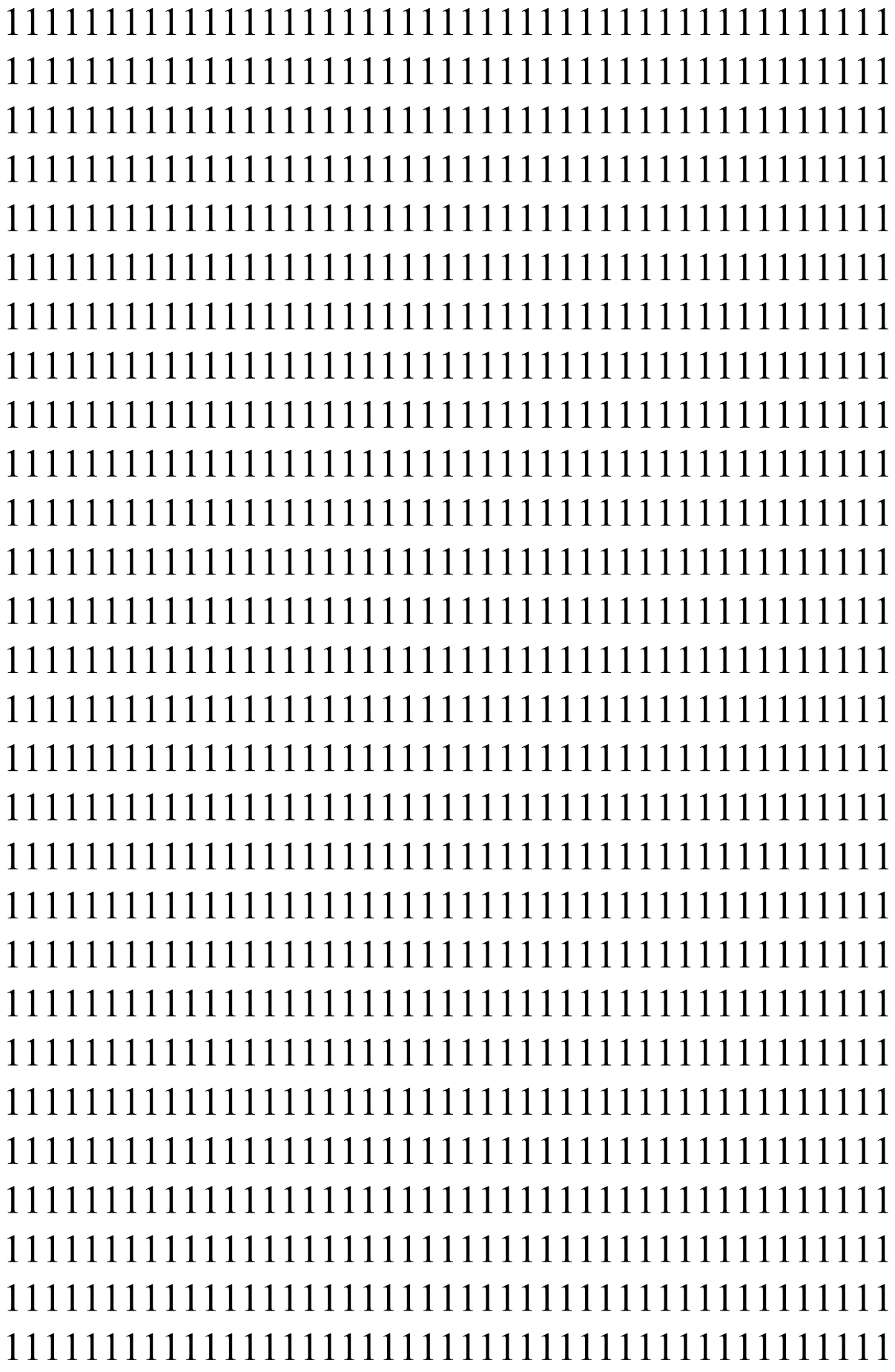


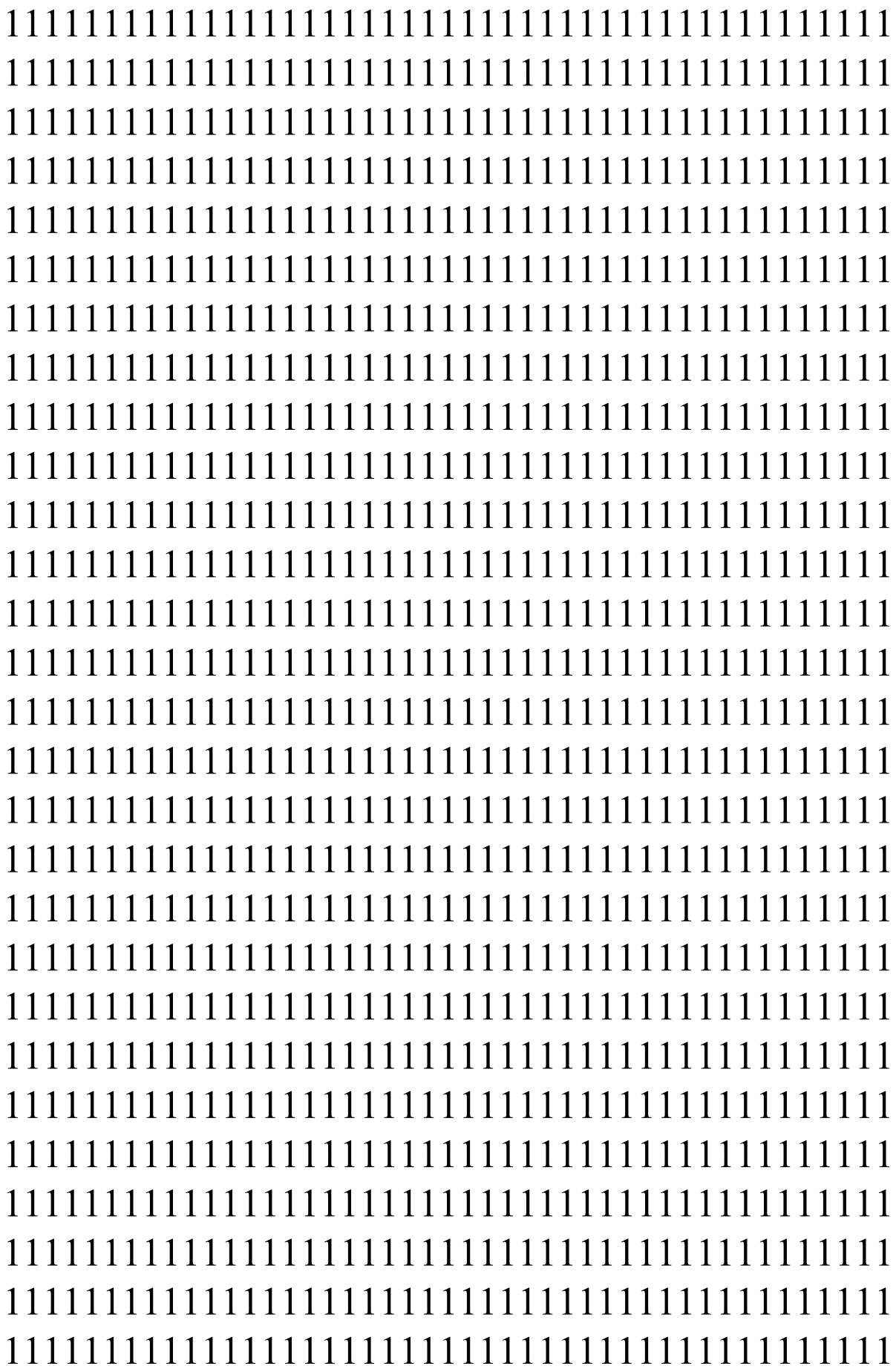


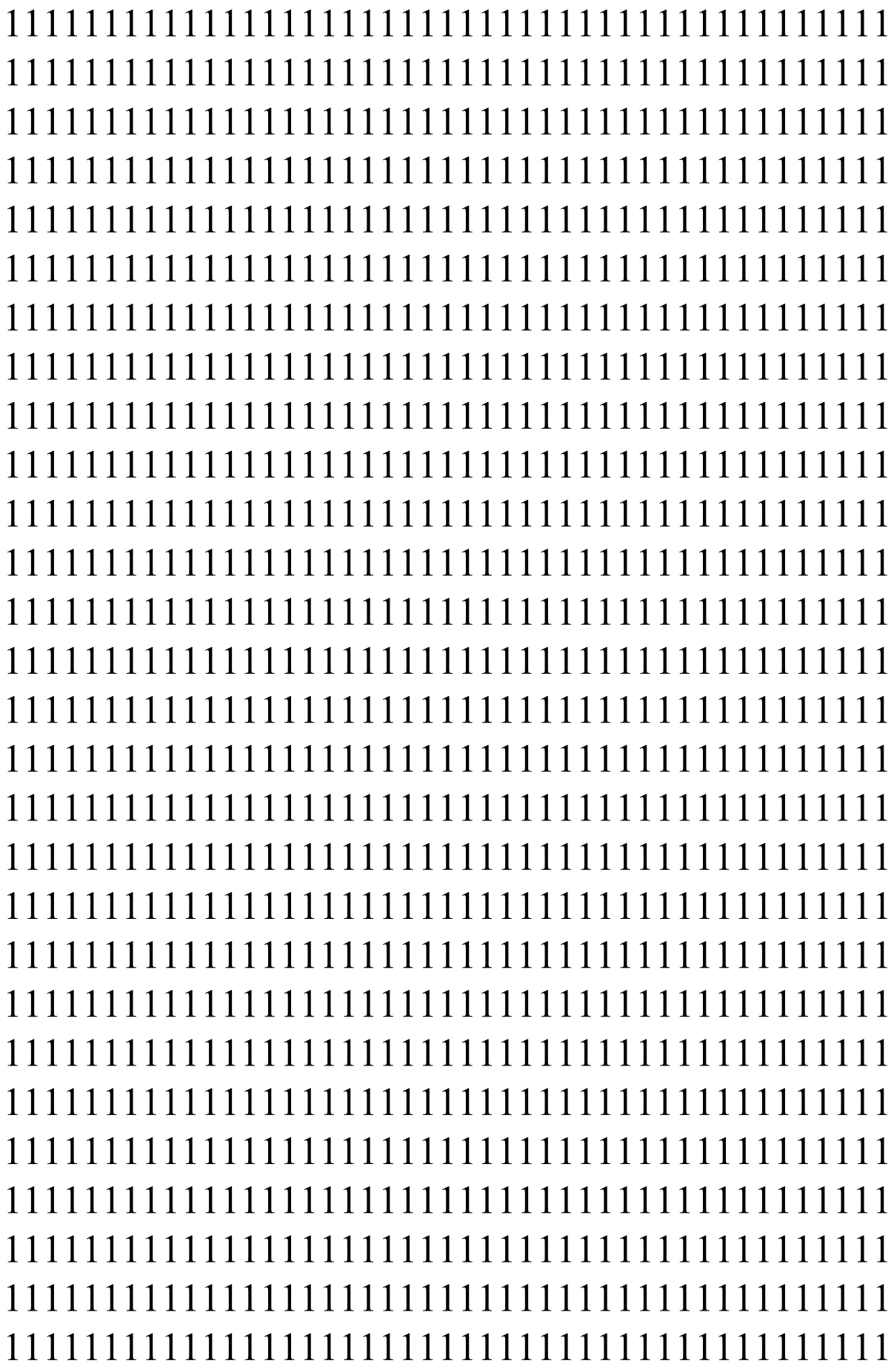


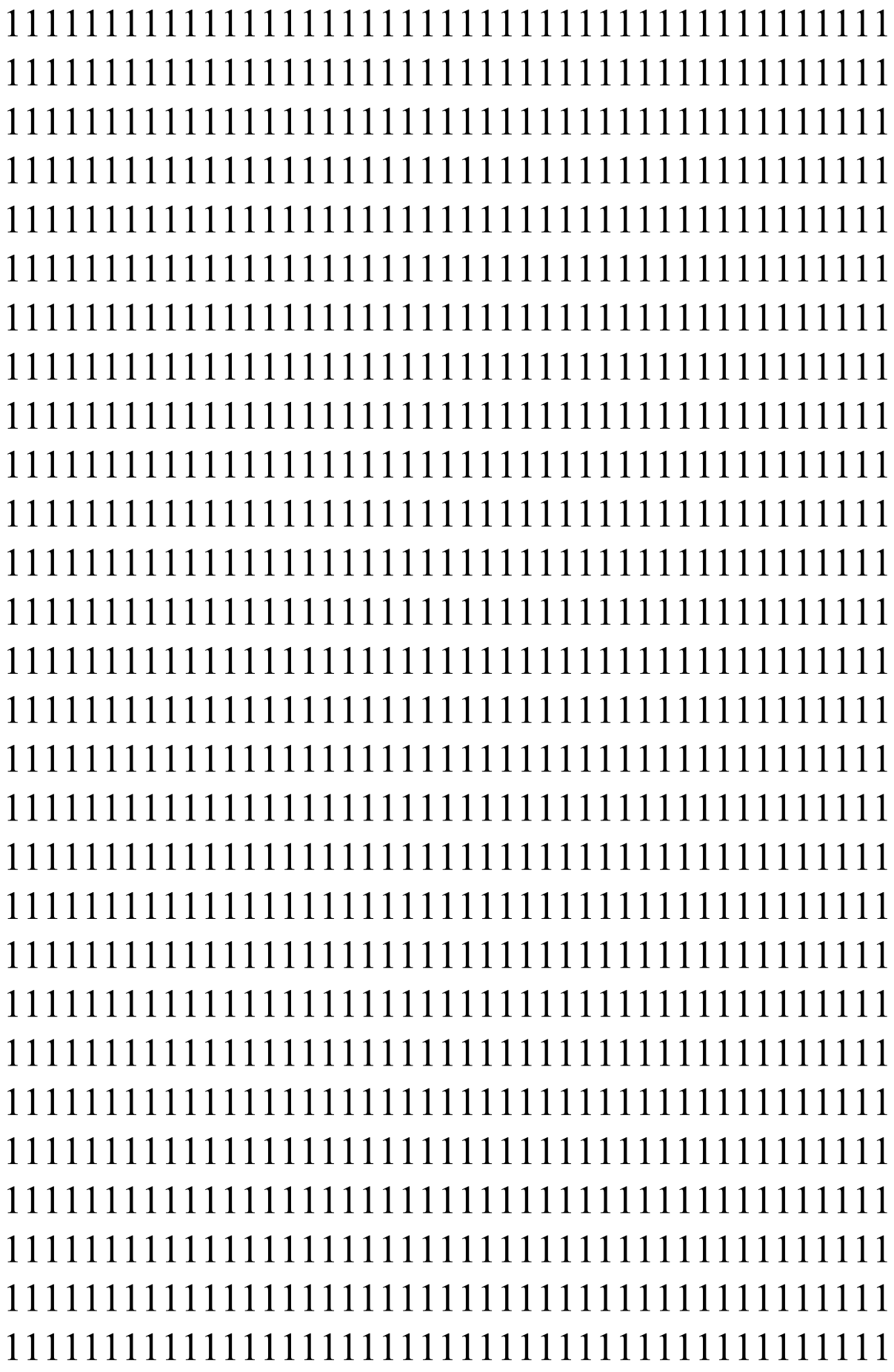


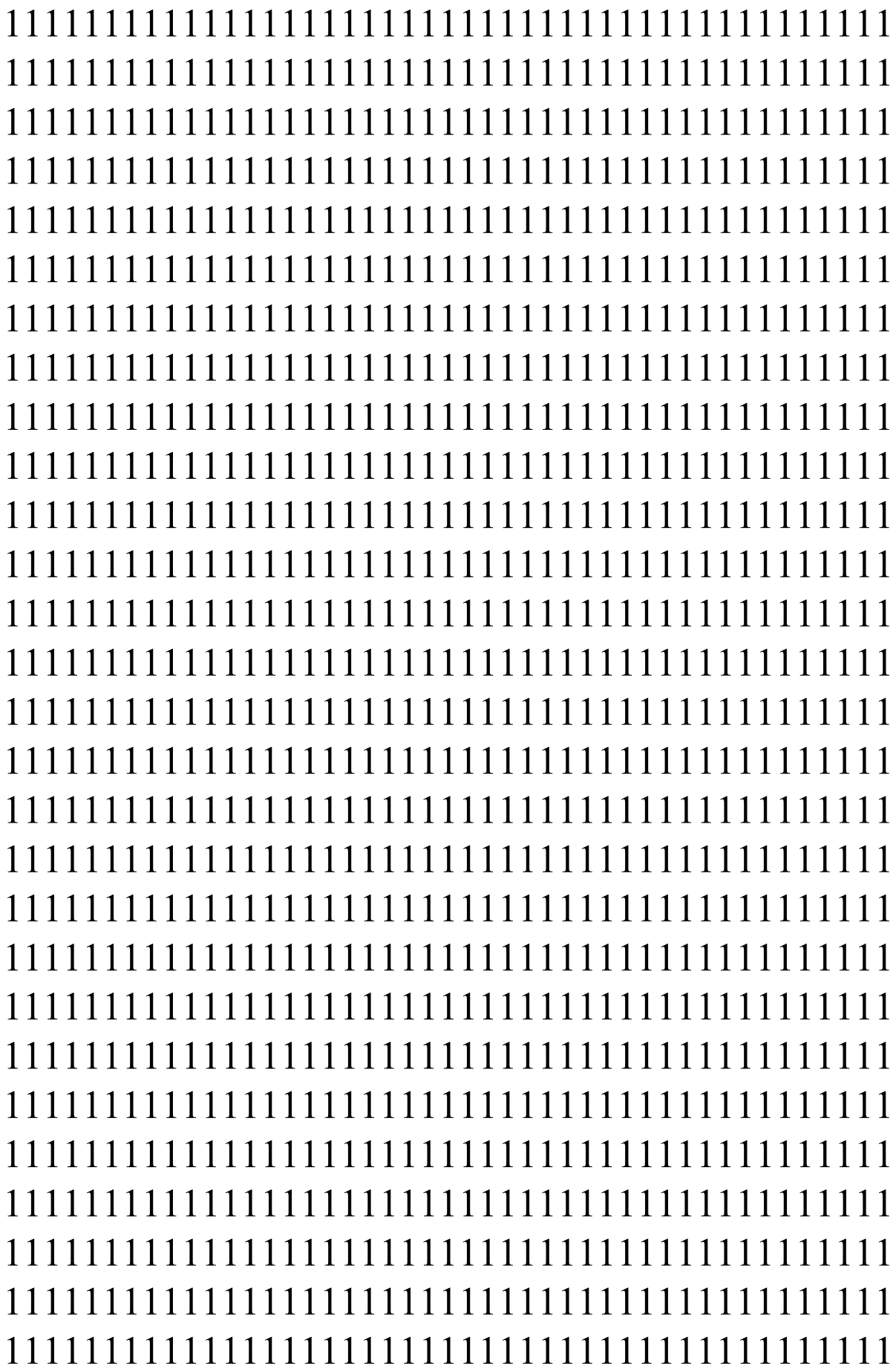


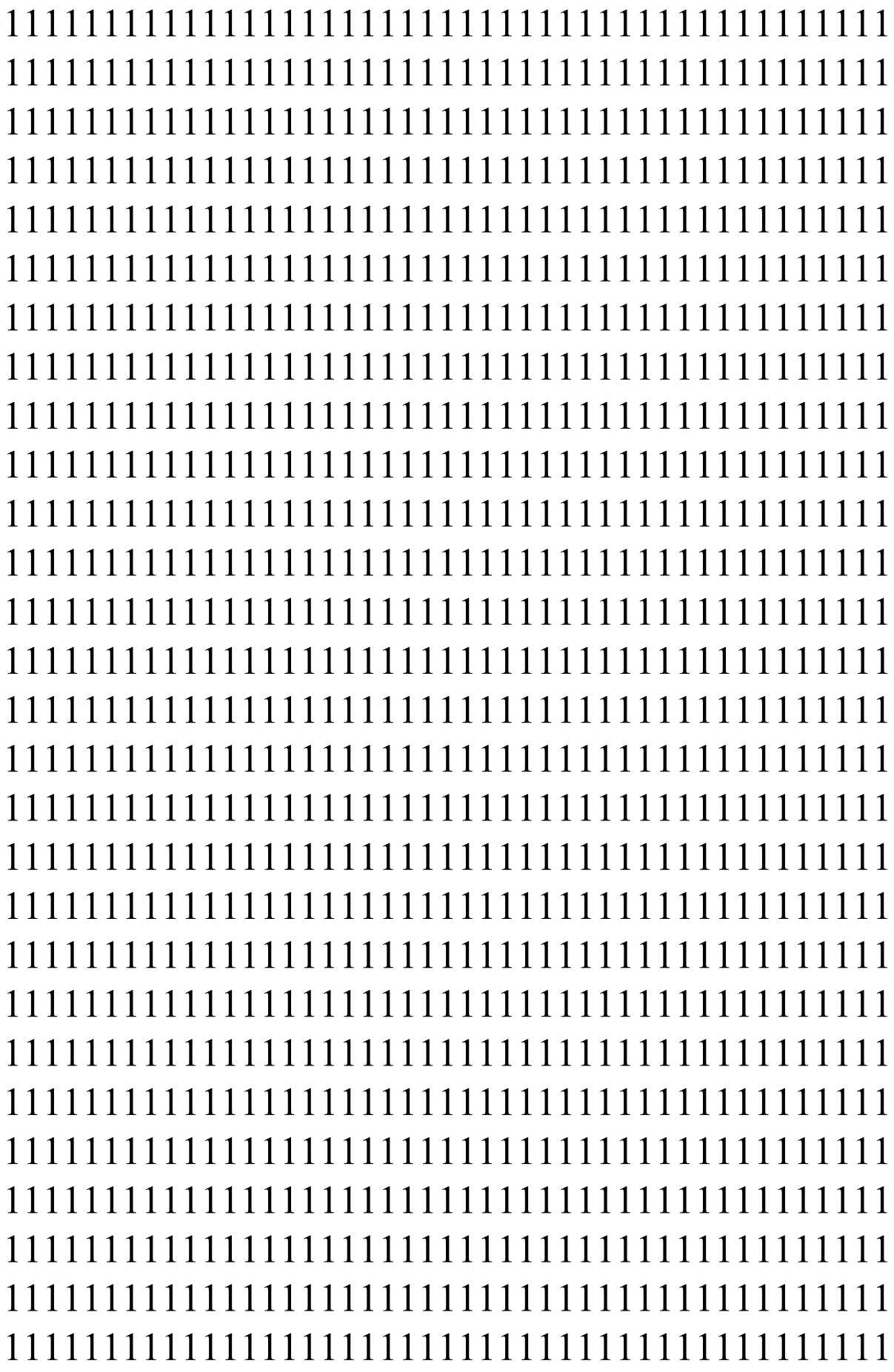


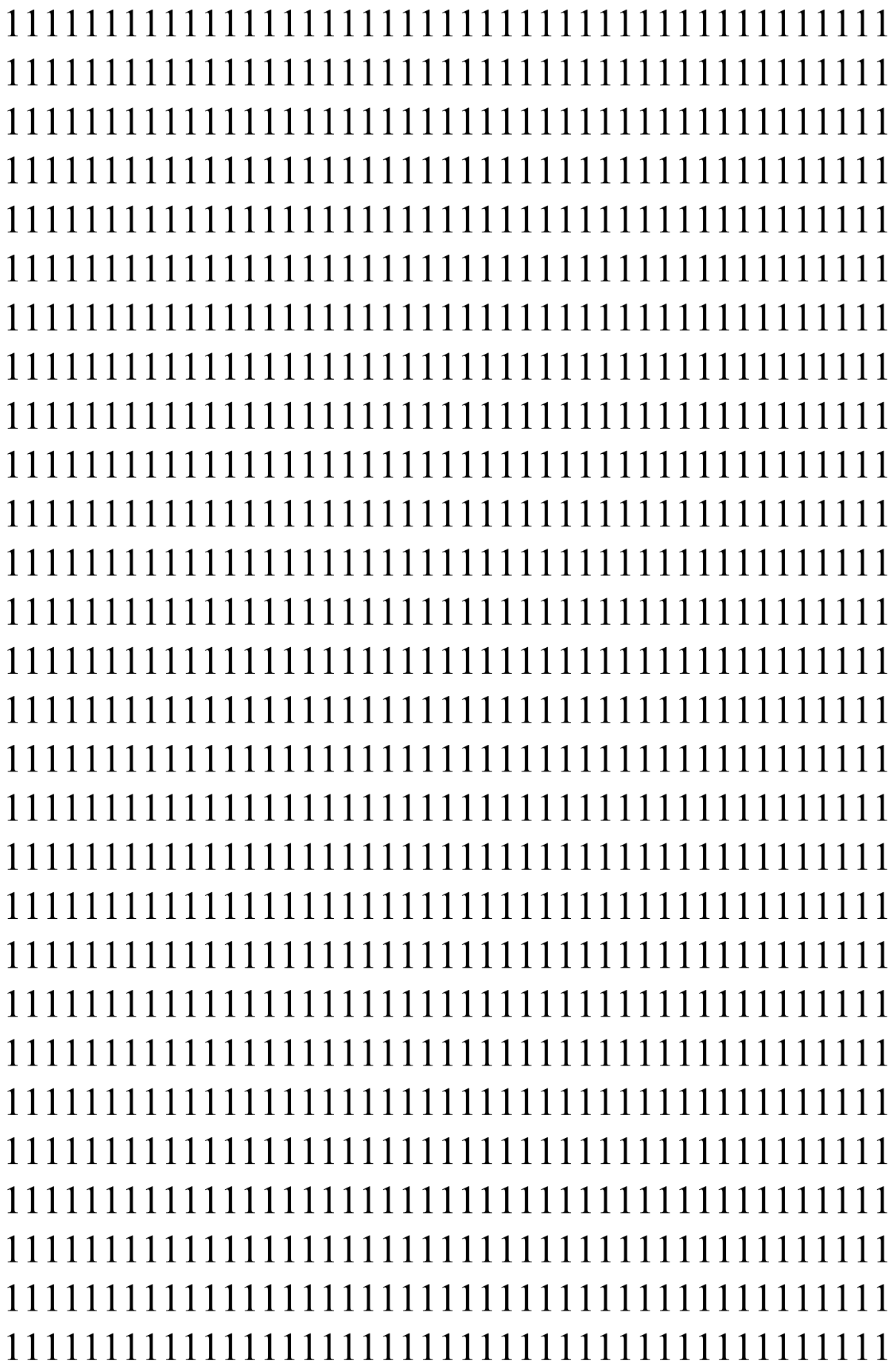


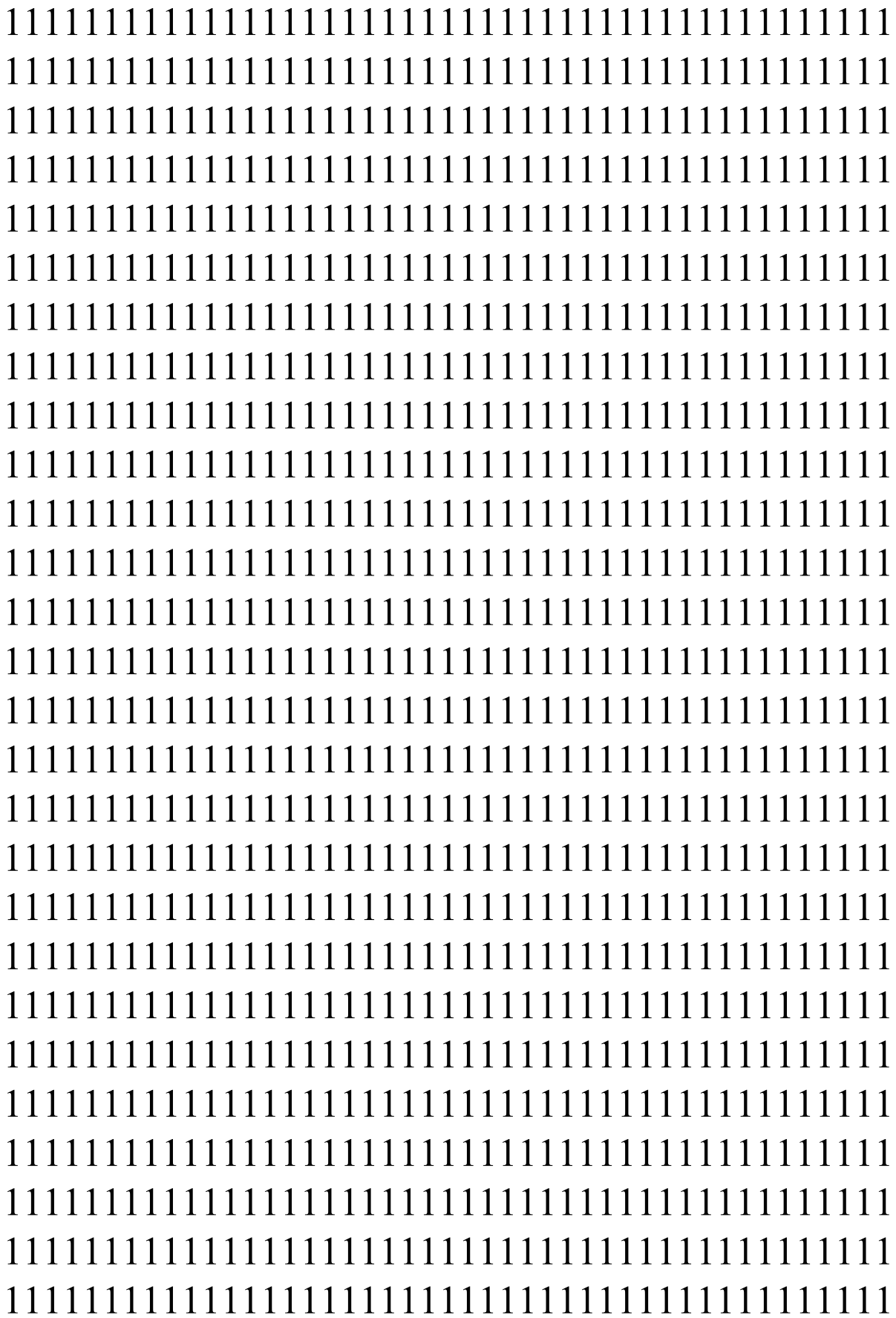












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Epilogue

Everything, 2002

“And myself have awaked, as it seems, to the better mind;
It is better to fight for the good than to rail at the ill;
I have felt with my native land, I am one with my kind,
I embrace the purpose of God, and the doom assigned.”

Glossary of Old High German

Ih - I, Du - You Singular

Lôrihhîn - The rabbit.

Wefsa - The wasp

Reigaro - The Heron

Kraa - The crow

Weralt - the world

Lant - The land

Bodam - The soil

Stilli - Calm

Wald / Woods - The Wood

Sterro - The Star

Sturm - The Storm

Blic - The lightning

Lioht - The light

Regan - The rain

Brennen / Brinnan - To Burn

Lesken - To extinguish

Wîb - the woman

Fihu - Livestock

Jungeling - the young man

Gomman - The Husband

Kind - the child

Taron - to ingure

Leiba - the remains

Enti - the end

Anafang - the beginning

Ein zwene dri fior fimf sehs sibun ahto niun zehan – 1 Through 10

Haggo - the hook

Klâftra - To fathom

Tagarôt(î) - The dawn

Morganer - tomorrow

Ubamorgane - the day after tomorrow

Wintar - the winter

Stinkan - to smell

Hôrehhen - to listen

Sela - soul or spirit

Wola - The good luck

Wêwa - the bad luck

Kussen - to kiss

Irbarmida - the pity

Angust - the fear

Unsuntîg - guilty

Anaran - the attadck

Enkilin - The grandchild

Fleisc - The Flesh

Bluot - The blood

Bein - The Bone

Houbit - Head

Gisiht - Face

Ouga - The eyebrow

Herza - Heart

Lungunna - The Lung

Ih Troumen - I dream

Samantwist - To have sex

Leben - To be alive

Toden - To Kill

Bigraban - To bury

Lihhamo - The corpse

Gisunt - Healthy

Jukkido - The itch

Krazzon - To scratch

Muodi - To rest

Nackot - Naked

Ful - Rotten

Scala - the dish

Untarn - the lunch

Quemaling - the stranger

Scalc - the slave

Truhtîn - the master

Kunigin - the queen

Skopf - the poet

Got - the god

Êwawarto - the priest

Unholda - the demon

Hella / himil - hell / heaven

Forazeihhan - the omen

Wesan - to be

Werdan - to become

Niowiht - nothing

Skellen - To peel

Krazzon - To Scrape

Hackon - To Chop

Brehhan - to break

Rinta - Bark

Saf - Sap

Sumph - tree stump

Eih - Oak

Pinboum - pine

Boum - tree

Wurzala - root